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National Edition



Limbu music videos to preserve Limbu culture: P.7



Govt, ADBL ink agreement for VITA Project: P.2

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President opens reconstruction meet

Nepal's post-quake reconstruction unprecedented

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

The international community has termed Nepal's post-quake reconstruction campaign successful and 'unprecedented event' in post-disaster management.

Speaking at the International Conference on Nepal's Reconstruction (ICNR) 2021 organised by National Reconstruction Authority (NRA) and inaugurated by President Bidya Devi Bhandari on Wednesday in the Capital, they expressed satisfaction over the timely completion of the reconstruction of private houses, heritages and infrastructures damaged in the 2015 earthquake.

Meanwhile, through the conference, Nepal has sent appreciation to the supporters, donors and collaborators of the reconstruction.

Foreign Minister of China, Wang Yi, congratulated Nepal government and people, and said that the northern neighbour would continue support to Nepal in rehabilitating livelihood. He also pledged to enhance vaccine cooperation. However, he maintained that there would not be any political conditions for any Chinese cooperation to Nepal.



President Bidya Devi Bhandari addressing the International Conference on Nepal's Reconstruction 2021 held in the capital on Wednesday.
(Photo: Sujan Gurung/TRN)

Expressing happiness over the near-completion of the reconstruction in a video message, Minister Wang said that China supported Nepal in the reconstruction of the projects like Nine-Storey Palace, Arniko Highway and Durbar High School.

Indian Minister for External Affairs, S. Jaishankar, also remembered in his video message that India started supporting Nepal government six hours after the quake struck the country.

"India will always come forward to support Nepal and its people in need. India has supported the reconstruction of about 50,000 quake-damaged houses in Nuwakot and Gorkha districts," he said.

Remarkable success

Speaking at the conference, Ambassador of the United States of America to Nepal, Randy Berry, said that his country has been helping Nepal in combating disasters and climate change. "The USA has provided support of US$240 million to Nepal after the 2015 quake," he said. According to him, Nepal has achieved a remarkable success in the post-quake reconstruction.

Neil Buhne, Regional Director for the UN Development Coordination Office, said that Nepal is extremely vulnerable to the effects of climate change as well as floods and landslides and expressed concerns that vulnerable people experience the major setbacks during the hard times.

Japanese Parliamentary Vice Minister for Foreign Affairs, Honda Taro, congratulated Nepal over the success of the reconstruction campaign. "This is not a small feat. Japan knows what it takes to recover and the hardships that accompany the process of reconstruction," he said.

According to him, Japan had pledged the support of US$260 million at the first edition of ICNR in June 2015. Japan has long been supporting Nepal in the field of disaster reduction and risk mitigation.

See page 6

PM for convening 19th SAARC Summit early

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8



Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba stressed the need to drive the SAARC process with a forward-looking perspective and revitalize it including through an early convening of the 19th Summit.

Extending greetings to the peoples and governments of the member states on the occasion of the 37th SAARC Charter Day, the Prime Minister said an embodiment of common aspirations for peace, stability and prosperity, the Charter was a blueprint of regional cooperation and partnership.

Over the period of three decades and a half, the regional efforts aimed at promoting the welfare of our peoples have yielded some notable progress, said Prime Minister Deuba adding, “However, the Charter objectives and aspirations are far from being fully realized.”

“Our endeavours to promote regional harmony, end poverty and inequality, and build just and inclusive societies are yet to gather requisite strength,” he added.

The Prime Minister referred to the challenges and vulnerabilities posed by the COVID-19 pandemic and underlined the need to re-embrace regional understanding and solidarity, with a focus on resilient recovery and building back better.

“We must strive towards deeper regional integration with a focus on resilient recovery and building back better,” the Prime Minister said.

He also reiterated Nepal’s commitment to playing a constructive role in enabling the organisation to deliver wider benefits for the peoples of the region and urged the Member States to promote more effective and result-oriented SAARC grounded in cooperation, trust and understanding.

Our endeavours to promote regional harmony, end poverty and inequality, and build just and inclusive societies are yet to gather requisite strength.

Home to over one-fifth of humanity, South Asia is a region of immense potentials common values and socio-cultural affinities, the Prime Minister said, adding, “In order to unlock these potentials, we must muster political will and drive the regional process with a forward-looking perspective.”

Vivah Panchami observed in Janakpur

By Dharbendra Jha
Janakpurdham, Dec. 8

Vivah Panchami, the day when Lord Ram married Goddess Sita in Janakpur, the capital of ancient Mithila, was celebrated with fanfare and gaiety in Janakpur on Wednesday. A marriage ceremony of Ram and Sita took place in the evening. Earlier in the afternoon, a Swayambhar ceremony was performed in the Ranga Bhumi ground of Janakpur.

The women of the Mithila community sang songs, danced, and entertained the visitors during the ceremony organised on the sixth day of the week-long festival. With a belief that the Swayambhar was held in the Ranga Bhumi ground in Treta epoch, the locals conduct the ceremony in the same place every year during Vivah Panchami.

Devotees from various parts of Nepal and India participated in the ceremony.

Ram Tapeshwor Das, priest of Janaki Temple, said, "After the conclusion of the Swayambhar ceremony, the wedding ceremony of Lord Ram and Goddess Sita will be held on the temple premises on Wednesday night as per the Mithila rituals."

NC leaders in hectic parleys to decide on consensus candidates

By Ram Prasad Dahal
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

As four days are left to file candidacy for the 14th general convention of the Nepali Congress, top leaders are in hectic parleys to decide on consensus candidates including the party president.

Leaders of both the factions -- led by party president Sher Bahadur Deuba and senior leader Ram Chandra Paudel -- were in intensified meetings on Wednesday. But the names of the candidates were not finalised till the evening.

Moreover, the Paudel faction could not pick a single candidate for party president despite its marathon meetings on Tuesday and Wednesday.

All three factions -- led by Prime Minister and party president Deuba, senior leader Paudel and leader Krishna Prasad Sitaula -- held separate meetings in bid to select consensus candidates and finalise names from their respective panels.

The NC Central Election Committee has already made public the calendar of election programme under 14th general convention. As per the calendar, voters’ list would be made public on December 10, the day when the general convention will begin. Likewise, the candidates should file their nominations on December 11 and voting will take place on December 13.



The meeting of the establishment faction held at Prime Minister and NC president Deuba’s private residence in Budhanilkantha concluded Deuba should lead the party for another term.

After the meeting, leader Dila Sagraula informed that the meeting unanimously asked Deuba to stand for party president for the next term.

The meeting decided that the panel of Deuba loyal candidates would contest election under the leadership of Prime Minister Deuba.

In the meeting, Home Minister Bal Krishna Khand, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Gyanendra Bahadur Karki, joint general secretary Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, spokesperson Bishwa Prakash Sharma and leader NP Saud claimed for party general secretary from the team.

Other leaders also claimed for the post of party office bearers. However, the meeting did not take any decision.

The meeting gave the responsibility to nine central leaders to prepare the list of Central Working Committee member aspirants from the panel.

Saud and Ramesh Lekhak, general secretary Purna Bahadur Khadka and Karnali Province Chief Minister and NC leader Jeevan Bahadur Shahi, Home Minister Khand, leader Gopal Man Shrestha, Dr. Mahat, Ramesh Rijal and Minister and leader Karki got the responsibility to prepare the list from Sudurpaschim, Karnali, Lumbini, Gandaki, Bagmati, Province 2 and Province 1 respectively. The meeting is to continue on Thursday.

The faction led by Paudel held its meeting at the Chaksibari-based residence of leader Prakash Man Singh. But the meeting failed to garner consensus after Singh stood firm about his candidacy for party president. Senior leader Paudel, general secretary Dr. Shashank Koirala and leader Dr. Shekhar Koirala, however, were in favour of consensus.

After the meeting, leader Guru Ghimire informed that the meeting failed to pick a single candidate for party president from the rival faction as Singh did not budge from his claim.

Leader Hirdayaram Thani also said the Central Working Committee members loyal to Paudel faction asked the four leader to reach a consensus. “They have to learn from their fathers, who did not show greed for any political post,” he said.

See page 6

'Make Nepali products more competitive'



By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

Finance Minister Janardan Sharma has said that domestic products must be made competitive to replace imports.

Addressing the 45th annual general meeting of NADA Automobiles Association of Nepal on Wednesday, Minister Sharma said that domestic products should be made competitive instead of restricting imports.

"We need a policy to make domestic goods competitive. I am not saying that imports should be banned. This is not possible today because of various international laws and treaties," he said.

See page 6

India’s defence chief killed in helicopter crash

AP
New Delhi, Dec. 8

India’s military chief, Gen. Bipin Rawat, and 12 others were killed Wednesday in a helicopter crash in southern Tamil Nadu state, the air force said. It said in a tweet that the helicopter “met with a tragic accident.”



The dead included Rawat’s wife. The air force said one officer, Group Capt. Varun Singh, survived and is being treated in a military hospital.

Public broadcaster Prasar Bharati said the Mi-17V5 helicopter was on its way from an air force base to the army defense services college when it crashed near the town of Coonoor, a hill station in Tamil Nadu. The reason for the crash was not immediately known.

Television images from the crash site showed plumes of smoke billowing from the debris as local residents tried to put out the fire and remove bodies from the wreckage.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said Rawat contributed greatly to modernizing the country’s armed forces. “His insights and perspectives on strategic matters were exceptional,” Modi said.

See page 6

Valley hospitals prepare to fight probable Omicron cases

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

The new variant of COVID-19, known as Omicron, has already spread in scores of countries across the world. So far, Nepal has recorded two cases of Omicron variant some 12 days after it was reported for the first time by South Africa and four days after it was detected in India.

The Ministry of Health and Population (MoHP) had confirmed two cases of Omicron variant on Monday, December 6. The World Health Organisation (WHO) has already classified Omicron as the 'Variant of Concern'.

The MoHP has requested the public to continue following all the health and safety standards and participating in the government's vaccination drive to stay safe from the variant. Dr. Santosh Dulal, research scientist and COVID-19 lab chief at Aanandaban Hospital, said that abiding by the public health standards was vital as the Omicron variant could possibly spread faster than other variants.

Similarly, Dr. Sher Bahadur Pun, chief of clinical research unit at Teku Hospital, said that rather than being terrified of the new variant, we should focus on alertness. "As researches are underway to determine the severity and transmissibility of Omicron, we are currently at 'wait and see ' situation," he said.

Dr. Manisha Rawal, director of Teku Hospital, also said that following public health standards could prevent the rapid spread of the new variant.

While the cases of new variant are being seen in the USA, India, UK and other European countries, the government is mulling over the measures to prevent the spread. The COVID-19 hospitals within the Kathmandu Valley have already adopted high alertness.



Armed Police Force Hospital

Dr. Prabin Nepal, focal person of the hospital, informed that the hospital was ready to battle the new variant in case it spread rapidly. "We have readied isolation ward with 200 beds. Also, if the cases of new variant start increasing, then we will separate 30 beds for Intensive Care Unit (ICU)," he added.

Dr. Nepal said that an oxygen plant of 100 litres had been installed in the hospital and the hospital was planning to set up another oxygen plant with a capacity of 200 litres.

Civil Service Hospital

Civil Service Hospital is also prepared to fight the new variant, informed Dr. Bidesh Bista, focal person of the hospital. He said, "Our hospital had started preparations for the possible third wave. Thus, we are already prepared to tackle Omicron variant."

Dr. Bista informed that 50 High Dependency Units and 15 ICU beds were separated for COVID-19 patients. We are preparing to begin the operation of COVID-19 ward within a week, he said, adding that an oxygen plant with 200 litres capacity had been installed in the hospital.

See page 6

BUSINESS



Bullion

Hallmark Gold= Rs. 92,300 per tola
Worked Gold= Rs. 91,800 per tola
Silver= Rs. 1,200 per tola

Minister Jhakri wants to amend construction laws

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

Minister for Urban Development, Ram Kumari Jhakri, said that amendments to laws not to the bylaws were necessary to make the construction industry systematic and dignified.

Speaking at a programme organised by the Federation of Contractors Associations of Nepal (FCAN) before the beginning of a procession in Kathmandu to mark the 14th Construction Day on Wednesday, she said that the business needed construction-friendly laws.

According to her, amendment to the law was inevitable as there were problems in the construction industry from the selection of the project to the implementation stage.

Minister Jhakri informed that the government was preparing to bring a new Public Procurement Act by accommodating the feedbacks from the stakeholders. "The construction industry needs to be strong to keep the country's economy afloat," she said.

Stating that it is important for the society and the country as a whole to respect the builders, she suggested the construction businessmen to increase their capacity.

She urged the construction companies to be merged and converted into public companies. Ministry Jhakri also said that the rights and interests of the workers in the construction industry should be secured.

President of the FCAN, Ravi Singh, said that the vision of a prosperous country is impossible without the development and expansion of the construction industry.

Stating that there are many problems in the construction industry, he said that the federation is hopeful that the current government will bring business-friendly laws.

The procession started from Dasharath Stadium with a display of placards and reached the FCAN Secretariat, Anamnagar.

Thirty-four people donated blood in a programme organized at the secretariat on the occasion.

NAC adds flights to Karnali, Sudurpashchim

By Rajan Rawat
Humla, Dec. 8

The state-owned Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) has once again added flights to the mountainous districts of Karnali and Sudurpashchim provinces.

Chief of NAC's Humla office Dan Bahadur Sunar informed that the airlines had added three weekly flights to Simkot, taking the total to four. "Upon our request, the head office added flights to accommodate the large number of passengers," he said.

NAC used to operate three flights a week from Nepalgunj to Simkot till before Tihar. However, it and other private carriers decreased the number of flights to Humla after the festivals, making it difficult for people to travel in and out of this district which lacks road access.

People of Humla prefer flying by Nepal Airlines because its fares are cheaper. It only charges Rs. 7,315 per passenger for charter flights from Nepalgunj to Simkot while private airlines charge up to Rs. 11,000.

Meanwhile, Chief of NAC Nepalgunj office Kiran Shrestha informed that the Corporation offered four weekly flights to Humla and Mugu and two weekly flights to Jumla with subsidised fares to serve the people of the rural areas.

"We have also sought permission to fly to Juphal, Dolpa, and have started flying to Bajura, Dipayal, Bajhang, Sanfe Bagar and Doti," Shrestha added.



Govt, ADBL ink agreement for VITA Project

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8



An agreement has been signed between the government of Nepal and the Agricultural Development Bank (ADBL) for the implementation of Value Chains for Inclusive Transformation of Agriculture (VITA) project.

The government and the ADBL have signed a subsidiary loan agreement worth USD 83.35 million.

The agreement was signed by Anil Kumar Upadhyay, Chief Executive Officer of the ADBL, and Dhakaram Tiwari, Acting Chief of the Public Debt Management Office on behalf of the government of Nepal, Tuesday.

According to the bank, the project is expected to benefit 125,000 farmers within a period of six years.

The project, which targets to develop and expand the agricultural value chain, aims to provide concessional loans to farmers as well as increase farmers' capacity in collaboration with Heifer International.

The ADBL will receive the loan amount through the Ministry of Finance with the assistance of the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) for a period of 30 years at an interest rate of 5 per cent.

The ADBL has been able to get this kind of concessional loan assistance after a long time, it said.

The bank said that such a programme would help the government of Nepal to reduce liquidity crunch in the banking market.

Major outage at Amazon disrupts businesses across the US

AP
Washington, Dec. 8

A major outage in Amazon's cloud computing network Tuesday severely disrupted services at a wide range of U.S. companies for more than five hours, the latest sign of just how concentrated the business of keeping the internet running has become.

The incident at Amazon Web Services mostly affected the eastern U.S., but still impacted everything from airline reservations and auto dealerships to payment apps and video streaming services to Amazon's own massive e-commerce operation. That included The Associated Press, whose publishing system was inoperable for much of the day, greatly limiting its ability to publish its news report.

Amazon has still said nothing about what, exactly, went wrong. In fact, the company limited its communications Tuesday to terse technical explanations on an AWS dashboard and a brief statement delivered via spokesperson Richard Rocha that acknowledged the outage had affected Amazon's own warehouse and delivery operation but said the company was "working to resolve the issue as quickly as possible."

Roughly five hours after numerous companies and other organizations began reporting issues, the company said in a post on the AWS status page that it had "mitigated" the underlying problem responsible for the outage, which it did not describe. It took some affected companies hours more to thoroughly check their systems and restart their own services.

Amazon Web Services was formerly run by Amazon CEO Andy Jassy, who succeeded founder Jeff Bezos in July. The cloud-service operation is a huge profit center for Amazon. It holds roughly a third of the $152 billion market for cloud services, according to a report by Synergy Research — a larger share than its closest rivals, Microsoft and Google, combined.

Japan economy contracts 3.6% in 3Q

AP
Tokyo, Dec. 8

Japan's economy contracted at a 3.6% annual rate in July-September as a wave of coronivirus infections crimped travel and other activities, the government said Wednesday.

The estimate for the last quarter, downgraded from an earlier report of a 3.0% contraction, reflected weakness in consumer spending and trade, the government said.

In quarterly terms, the measure used for most economies, the economy contracted 0.9%, compared to the earlier estimate of a 0.8% contraction.

The world's third-largest economy was in a slump before the pandemic hit. Its recovery has been fitful thanks to precautions taken to curb COVID-19 infections. Troubles with supply chains, especially for computer chips used in autos, have also taken a toll.

Cultivation of Boro paddy starts in Jhapa

By Our Correspondent
Damak, Dec. 8



Cultivation of Boro paddy has started in Jhapa. Plantation of the new paddy has already started even when many farmers have not completed harvesting of the paddy.

With the introduction of new species of paddy, farmers can now grow paddy three times a year in the district. Boro paddy should be planted by the second week of Mangsir.

Paddy is especially planted up to twice a year. But in recent times, farmers have started producing paddy thrice a year. Earlier, farmers in Kachankawal district had grown paddy thrice a year.

Multipurpose Joint Agricultural Firm of Kamal Rural Municipality-1, Jhapa has planted paddy within the month of Mangsir.

According to Rabindra Subedi, chief of the Prime Minister's Agriculture Modernisation Project Implementation Unit, Bhadrapur, various uses of paddy farming have been taking place in Jhapa and the attraction of farmers towards a new variety of Boro paddy farming has started.

According to Subedi, this confirms the possibility of cultivating paddy up to three times a year in the district where there is irrigation facility.

He also said that the multi-purpose joint agricultural firm has cultivated Boro paddy in 8 katthas of land.

Subedi said that the farmers may have planted paddy in 8 to 10 hectares of land only in the month of Mangsir.

According to agricultural technicians, the paddy planted this month will be ready to be harvested in 90 to 95 days.

It is said that this will help in food security and will also benefit the farmers. While cultivating winter and rainy paddy, farmers have repeatedly complained that they have not received the price of paddy.

For the expansion of paddy cultivation, the Prime Minister's Agriculture Modernisation Project Implementation Unit, Jhapa has been providing support in sustaining the infrastructure, production and productivity condition, mechanisation, processing and marketing condition of Paddy Superzone area.

It has also supported the farmers with required technology.

Paddy Superzone programme was implemented in some wards of Kachankawal and Bhadrapur in the district from the fiscal year 2015/16. Lately, this programme has been implemented in 15 municipalities of Jhapa since the fiscal year 2019/20.

The farmers have been cultivating paddy in spring and autumn. Boro paddy farming started only a few years ago.

Share Trading

Wednesday's share prices

Traded Companies	Closing Price	Previous Closing	Difference Rs.
Unilever Nepal Limited	18155	18401	-246
Rastriya Beema Company Limited	16399	16562	-163
Rastriya Beema Company Limited Promoter Share	12800	13000	-200
Bottlers Nepal (Terai) Limited	12000	12577.4	-577.4
Himalayan Distillery Limited	5650	5897	-247
Salt Trading Corporation	5460	5665.9	-205.9
Bishal Bazar Company Limited	4690	4899.1	-209.1
Jeevan Bikas laghubitta bittya sanstha ltd	3992	4080	-88
Mahila Lagubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	3635	3738	-103
National Microfinance Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	2996	3088.2	-92.2
Citizen Investment Trust	2885	2975	-90
Forward Community Microfinance Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	2649.9	2647	2.9
Swabhimaan Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	2540	2619	-79
Janautthan Samudayic Laghubitta Bikas Bank Ltd.	2410	2595	-185
Support Microfinance Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	2125	2155.2	-30.2
Life Insurance Co. Nepal	1849.5	1880	-30.5
Mahuli Samudayik Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	1760	1790	-30
Mithila LaghuBitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1725	1799	-74
Unnati Sahakarya Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1721	1737.2	-16.2
Manakamana Smart Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1610	1610	0
Shikhar Insurance Co. Ltd.	1585	1619	-34
Infinity Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1540	1585	-45
Manushi Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1518	1550	-32
Chhimek Laghubitta Bikas Bank Limited	1515	1545	-30
Global IME Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	1487	1550	-63
Sana Kisan Bikas Bank Ltd	1476	1510	-34
Nabil Bank Limited	1456.8	1475	-18.2
Nirdhan Utthan Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1434	1470	-36
Mirmire Microfinance Development Bank Ltd.	1407	1421	-14
Ganapati Microfinance Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1395	1440	-45
Summit Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1372	1409	-37
Vijaya laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	1370	1410	-40
Nepal Life Insurance Co. Ltd.	1366	1398.9	-32.9
Swabalamban Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1355.1	1399.1	-44
Samata Gharelu Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1350	1386	-36
Laxmi Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	1328.3	1381	-52.7
Chandragiri Hills Limited	1320.3	1350	-29.7
RMDC Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	1299	1342	-43
Nepal Doorsanchar Comapany Limited	1298.7	1326	-27.3
Sabaiko Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1271	1349	-78
Aarambha Chautari Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1267	1312	-45
Asha Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd	1265	1279	-14
Nerude Laghubita Bikas Bank Limited	1251	1277	-26
Naya Sarathi Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1240	1339	-99
Nepal Reinsurance Company Lim ited	1234	1230	4
Kisan Lagubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1231	1248.1	-17.1
Sadhana Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1188	1245	-57
Shivam Cements Ltd	1187	1211.3	-24.3
NMB Microfinance Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	1180	1201.5	-21.5
Kalika Microcredit Development Bank Ltd.	1174	1198	-24
Samudayik Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1168	1277	-109
Gurans Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1155	1233	-78
Sagarmatha Insurance Co. Ltd.	1140	1176.2	-36.2
Deprosc Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1115	1157	-42
Asian Life Insurance Co. Limited	1098.9	1120	-21.1
NIC ASIA Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Limited	1070	1100	-30
Mountain Energy Nepal Limited	1053.6	1055	-1.4
Mero Microfinance Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	1045	1097	-52
Neco Insurance Co. Ltd.	1037	1065	-28
Manjushree Finance Ltd.	1025	1035	-10
Swarojgar Laghu Bitta Bikas Bank Ltd.	999	1029	-30
IME General Insurance Ltd.	953	965	-12
Shangri-la Development Bank Debenture 2087	951.1	955.2	-4.1
Civil Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	935	970	-35
Ru Ru Jalbidhyut Pariyojana Limited	910	904	6
Grameen Bikas Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	901	940.8	-39.8
Corporate Development Bank Limited	885	904	-19
Narayani Development Bank Limited	883	914.9	-31.9
Premier Insurance Co. Ltd.	876	886	-10
National Life Insurance Co. Ltd.	850	870	-20
Siddhartha Insurance Ltd.	800	824	-24
NLG Insurance Company Ltd.	798	835.3	-37.3
NIC Asia Bank Ltd.	749	766	-17
CEDB Hydropower Development Company Limited	736	759	-23
First Micro Finance Development Bank Ltd.	736	750	-14
Gurkhas Finance Ltd.	730	754	-24
Nepal Insurance Co. Ltd.	725	748	-23
Prabhu Insurance Ltd.	720	740	-20
ICFC Finance Limited	703.8	712	-8.2
Surya Life Insurance Company Limited	698	717	-19
Ajod Insurance Limited	684	677	7
RSDC Laghubitta Bittiya Sanstha Ltd.	682	695	-13
Prime Life Insurance Company Limited	639	653.8	-14.8
Goodwill Finance Co. Ltd.	638	670	-32
Lumbini General Insurance Co. Ltd.	630	643	-13
Ngadi Group Power Ltd.	620	640	-20
United Insurance Co. (Nepal) Ltd.	614.9	630	-15.1
Union Life Insurance Company Limited	608	621	-13
Prudential Insurance Co. Ltd.	604	613	-9
Himalayan General Insurance Co. Ltd	600.1	635.1	-35
Everest Insurance Co. Ltd.	600	618	-18
Upper Tamakoshi Hydropower Ltd	597	610	-13
Sahas Urja Limited	595	635	-40
Mahalaxmi Bikas Bank Ltd.	577	599	-22
Janaki Finance Ltd.	575	611	-36
Radhi Bidyut Company Ltd	563	582	-19
General Insurance Company Nepal Ltd	562	567	-5
NRN Infrastructure and Development Limited	560	586	-26
Excel Development Bank Ltd.	550.2	600	-49.8
Jyoti Life Insurance Ltd	544	565	-21

Total Amount Rs.	2,663,909,620
Total Quantity	6,560,947
Total No of Transactions	42,946

Man returns home quitting US govt job to toil for nation

By Bhotraj Rai
Udaypur, Dec. 8

Whereas many Nepalis give an arm and a leg to get a chance to go to the United States and settle there, one man from Bokse, Triyuga Municipality–10, Udaypur decided to leave the US and return home.

Prajwol Adhikari had an enviable life in the States. Having reached there for his studies in 2012, Adhikari worked for the postal service, had his own house and lived with his wife who worked as a nurse. But he left it all behind and came back to work in his own homeland.

"Things were good in the United States; we were comfortable. But comfort isn't everything," Adhikari shared with The Rising Nepal. "No amount of money and material facilities can compare to the value of Nepali land and Nepali culture. So, I decided to come and devote myself to my motherland."

He plans to do this by building a resort with a children's park, zip line, swings and party hall. He is currently building infrastructure for it at an investment of Rs. 50 million. Adhikari informed that his resort would focus on service more than profit.

"We will charge less and offer more," he said, talking about his plans. "We will provide healthy food in a family atmosphere and we'll utilise local resources and manpower."

"Those who grow up in small villages dream of going to the city. Once in the city, they want to live in Kathmandu. From Kathmandu, they again try desperately to move to western countries. "But no matter where we go, we are never satisfied and because of that, we never find happiness," Adhikari said. "I came back to find happiness and if my happiness helps develop my birthplace for others then, well, that's an added bonus."

Adhikari informed that he wished to keep the memory of his parents alive through his work.



Prajwol Adhikari (Photo: TRN)

He hopes to complete the resort, which is being constructed at a distance of around one kilometre from the district headquarters Gaighat, within a year. "We are currently flattening the land and constructing the meeting hall, restaurant, kitchen, toilets and parking lots. After this, we will begin gardening to make the area green and attractive and lastly, we will construct the zip line and the big swings."

Adhikari hopes that the spot will become an oasis for those looking for calmness and a pleasant atmosphere and will help bring in tourists as well. "Gaighat has a lot of facilities but it does not have a nice family resort. I want to change that," he said.

Adhikari added that he would equip the facility with state-of-the-art technology and design packages to take guests to scenic and tranquil destinations like Saptakoshi Chatara, Udayapurgadhi, Chaudandigadhi, Taplipokhari, Limchungbung and Halesi.

It is said that it takes great courage to contain one's desires and take the difficult road despite having easier alternatives available. Adhikari had that courage and that is why he returned, with his wife and two kids – nine and seven year olds, to Nepal to live a peaceful life.

He wants his efforts here to create employment opportunities so that other youths do not have to leave the country for work.

'Public should receive quality services easily'

By Our Correspondent
Nepalgunj, Dec. 8

Minister for Youths and Sports Maheshwor Jung Gahatraj 'Athak' Wednesday directed the government officials in Kohalpur, Banke, to create a system which would allow the public to avail services with ease.

Visiting his home town of Kohalpur, Minister Gahatraj had met with the chiefs and representatives of around a dozen government offices in the area.

Minister Gahatraj requested the chiefs to reach out in case they needed assistance to upgrade and improve the services.

"Public should not struggle to avail services from the government offices.

The offices should also complete development projects in time and utilise allocated budget properly," he said.

According to Kohalpur Municipal Chairman for Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist Centre) Avaraj Khadka, locals have been complaining about the delays and struggles to receive even the basic services from the government offices.

Minister Gahatraj also requested the chiefs to reach out in case they needed assistance to upgrade and improve the services through the respective offices.

Meanwhile, the local level representatives and government officials reminded the minister of the needed changes in policies to support infrastructural development.

Speaking at the meeting, former youth leader of CPN (Maoist Centre) Narendra Neupane informed that they were lobbying to setup new government offices like Land Revenue Office, trial services for driving license and many more in Kohalpur.

Postal highway construction gains momentum in Kailali

By Abinash Chaudhary
Dhangadhi, Dec. 8

The construction work on the remaining postal highway in the Basanta Corridor area in Kailali district has gained momentum.

After the retreat of monsoon, the construction work has been started in two kilometres (kms).

Earlier, the work could not be moved forward as the Federal Cabinet meeting delayed in issuing a go-ahead approval to cut down the trees in the area. In March last year, the Council of Ministers had ordered the local administer to manage the trees there.

After the government's decision, 100 trees were cut down one month later, but the rest of the work was put off because of the hailstorm.

Engineer Padam Madai, Information Officer of the Postal Highway Project Dhangadhi, said that the remaining road construction work had already started.

The work of laying gravel will start immediately after soil rolling, said Madai. "We have planned to lay gravel on the road by this January, 2022," he said. "But there has been a problem in managing gravel as it is not available nearby, it has to be brought from Karnali River," he added.

Tundi, Perera, Chandra and Basanta JV were awarded with the contract six years ago for the construction work in that section. However, the work was halted due to legal issues within two kms of the forest area.

Embankment construction paced up to protect Madi Bridge

By Our Correspondent
Tanahun, Dec. 8

The embankment construction to protect Madi Bridge, which connects wards 5 and 3 of Byas Municiplaity, is proceeding swiftly.

The 370-metre-long bridge was at risk as the river had been cutting the lands around.

The embankment is expected to eradicate the risk.

According to Road Division Office of Damauli, the project has been bankrolled by the federal government.

A total of Rs. 5.8 million has been allocated for the embankment.

"The flood had caused major damage in the area of Ward No. 3. Construction of gabion walls have started there. We aim to complete the embankment before the deadline," said Er. Subarna Shrestha, owner of Geru Construction Service, the company awarded with the project.

According to Shrestha, 15 people are working to construct embankment for a 76-metre area.

Gabion walls were constructed on the side of Ward No. 5 earlier, due to which only the area of Ward No. 3 has been affected by the floods during monsoon.

"The flood had entered in Bhateri, an area in Ward No. 3. Embanking the area properly will not only protect Bhateri but also Damauli bazaar," said Ashok Kumar Shrestha, a local.

Another local Chudamani Dahal said that a wall along Shantinagar and Durga Temple can protect around 300 houses in the area from floods, too.



Rhino swept away by Narayani, brought from India

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

A rhinoceros that was roaming around Tribenidham near the border with India is being brought back to the Chitwan National Park (CNP) by darting.

A team from CNP and National Trust for Nature Conservation (NTNC) reached Binaya Triveni Rural Municipality-6 in Nawalparasi and brought the rhino to the CNP by darting and was released into the core area of CNP, said information officer at CNP Ganesh Prasad Tiwari.

The male rhino, seven-to-eight-years old, was released into the Kulbo Community Forest, in the eastern part of CNP on Monday, he informed. "The rhino was travelling to India and Nepal frequently and living in the Nawalparsai area for a long time," he said. It was expected that the rhino reached India after being swept away by the flooded Narayani River some six years ago.

"We are able to bring it back after locals informed the park about the rhino grazing in the sugarcane fields of the Trivenidham area.

A team of technicians involved in the National Tiger Survey made the rhino unconscious and brought it to the eastern sector of CNP," Tiwari said.

A team led by Dr. Bijay Kumar Shrestha, a wildlife doctor from CNP, and Dr. Amir Sadaula, a wildlife doctor from the NTNC, reached the Binaya Triveni Rural Municipality on Sunday to dart the rhino.

The rhino was darted with the help of wildlife doctors, technicians and helpers, who arrived with six elephants and locals, Tiwari said.

City centre planned inside Butwal bus terminal

By Our Correspondent
Butwal, Dec. 8

Butwal sub-metropolitan city is planning to construct a multi-storey city centre inside the bus terminal in Butwal so that they can use it for multiple purposes. According to the plan, the building will be equipped with all modern facilities essential in a shopping complex.

Shivaraj Subedi, Chief Executive Officer of the sub-metropolitan city, said that the building construction will be carried out under public-private-partnership (PPP) model. "There is four bighas of land in Lumbini bus terminal, we will utilise it for building a multi-proposed city centre with parking facility," he added.

There is enough unused land on the bus park premise. And the local body plans constructing a building for commercial use. "Project execution process has already begun," Subedi said. Butwal Sub Metropolitan City had published a public notice for the purpose.

The municipality estimated the construction cost at Rs. 2 billion for the construction. It scrapped the previous 'Building Construction Code-2017 and introduced a newer one which allows for the construction of such buildings inside this city.

"Increasing density of the population caused land scarcity and it compelled us to amend the building code," Subedi said.

New building construction code allows for public land conservation and multi-storey building construction in Butwal. However, such buildings have to maintain a quake resilience mechanism and other specifications inside them.

Ram Prasad Regmi, spokesperson in the municipality, said that the designer, contractor and construction company will have to be responsible if faults are found in the construction. "They can't cross the limitations of national building code," he said.

Briefs

Man beaten to death

Bhaktapur: A man succumbed to injuries while undergoing treatment at Madhyapur Hospital on Tuesday.

The deceased has been identified as 33-year-old Rajan Shrestha. Locals had informed police that Shrestha was being beaten by some individuals near the bridge over the Hanumante River in Ward 2 of Suryabinayak Municipality.

Police officers from Balkot and Thimi were then immediately deployed towards the scene. They found Shrestha injured and rushed him to the hospital.

An investigation team has been formed and search for the culprits is on, informed Bhaktapur Police.

Worker dies in airport

Rupandehi: A worker died Tuesday at the construction site of the Gautam Buddha International Airport in Ward 4 of Siddharthanagar Municipality.

The deceased has been identified as 24-year-old Amrit Aryal, a resident of Arghakhanchi. Aryal died after being pressed by an iron net used to sieve sand.

According to police, the net tilted and pressed Aryal. Injured Aryal is said to have died during treatment at Bhairahawa-based medical college.

Police informed that they were conducting a necessary investigation into the incident.

16 gamblers held in Kathmandu

Kathmandu:Police have arrested 16 gamblers while they were playing dice on the third floor of an apartment at Bijeshwori of Swoyambhu in Kathmandu Metropolitan City-15.

Police have arrested 16 gamblers including Binita Pariyar, 31, of Bhojpur Arun Rural Municipality-1 and temporarily residing in Kalimati on Tuesday night.

Police from the Metropolitan Police Circle, Swoyambhu, busted them on the basis of information that they were playing dice in the apartment.

Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Milan KC said that action has been taken under the Gambling Act by keeping the arrested persons in custody.

Motorcycle kills elderly

Udaypur: An elderly died while receiving treatment at Biratnagar-based Neuro Hospitaly on Tuesday. Identified as 71-year-old Karna Sundas, he was hit by a motorcycle.

According to Udaypur District Police, the motorcycle (State 1-05-001 Pa 3592) en-route to Gaighat from Beltar had hit Sundas near Old Gaighat.

Injured Sundas, a resident of Triyuga Municipality, was then rushed to hospital.

"The motorcycle and its rider 29-year-old Biren Rai of Triyuga are in our custody. Necessary investigation and legal process is on," said DSP spokesperson for Udaypur Police Bed Prasad Gautam.

(TRN)

Nepal Electricity Authority
Generation Directorate
Durbarmarg, Kathmandu, Nepal

INVITATION FOR NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING

Notice Publication Date : 2078/08/23 (Dec 9th, 2021)

S.No.	Name of Power Plant/Office	IFB No.	IFB Name/Job Descriptions	Remarks
1.	Generation Directorate, Nepal Electricity Authority (01-4153014)	NEA-GEN-2078/79-EMT-01	Supply and delivery of Transformer oils and Lubricants at Respective NEA Power Stations	E-bid only
2.	Sunkoshi Hydropower Station, Lamasanghu, Sindhupalchowk (Ph: 011-482155)	NEA-SHPS-2078/079-ET-01	Supply and Delivery of Electrical spare parts for SCADA and Excitation system at SHPS	E-bidding Only
3.	Seti Phewa Hydropower Station, Nadipur-03, Kaski (Ph: 061-551245/521930)	NEA-SPHPS-2078-079-CSQ-01	Quarter repair and maintenance works for Setifewa Hydropower Station	E-bidding
For more details please visit PPMO website: www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp.				

बोलपत्र/दरभाउपत्र स्वीकृत गर्ने आशयको सूचना

(सूचना प्रकाशन मिति : २०७८।०८।२३)

ने.वि.प्रा., उत्पादन निर्देशनालय अन्तर्गत तपसिल बमोजिमका जलविद्युत केन्द्रहरूले निम्न उल्लेखित मितिमा "दि राइजिङ नेपाल" मा प्रकाशित सूचना अनुसार दर्ता हुन आएका बोलपत्र/दरभाउपत्रहरू मध्ये तल उल्लेखित बोलपत्र दाता/दरभाउपत्र दाताहरूको बोलपत्र/दरभाउपत्रहरू न्यूनतम मूल्याङ्कित सारभूत रूपमा प्रभावग्राही भई स्वीकृतिका लागि सिफारिस भई आएको हुँदा ने.वि.प्रा., आर्थिक प्रशासन विनियमावली २०६८ को विनियम १५६ तथा सार्वजनिक खरिद ऐन २०६३ को दफा २७ (२) को प्रयोजनका लागि यो सूचना प्रकाशित गरिएको छ।

क्र. सं.	बोलपत्र/दरभाउपत्र प्रकाशन मिति	बोलपत्र/ दरभाउपत्र नं. र कामको विवरण	छनोट भएको बोलपत्र दाता/ दरभाउपत्र दाताको नाम, ठेगाना	कबोल अंक ने.रु.
चमेलिया जलविद्युत केन्द्र, बलांच, दार्चुला (९९४९३००२०)				
१.	२०७८।०७।१५	NEA-CHEPS-2078/079-EMT-04 (Supply and Delivery of Mechanical Consumable & Maintanance Items at Chameliya Hydropower Station, Balanch, Darchula)	Malhotra Enterprises Pvt. Ltd., Kathmandu, Nepal	NRs. 32,25,997.45 With VAT
२.	२०७८।०७।१५	NEA-CHEPS-2078/079-EMT-05 (Supply and Delivery of Electrical Consumables & Spare Parts at Chameliya Hydropower Station, Balanch, Darchula)	E Coil Pvt. Ltd., Kathmandu, Nepal	NRs. 35,61,443.60 With VAT

नेपाल विद्युत प्राधिकरण
उत्पादन निर्देशनालय, रत्नपार्क, काठमाडौँ।

OP-ED

Thought For Today

Life isn't about finding yourself. Life is about creating yourself.
-- George Bernard Shaw

EDITORIAL

Cultural Value Of Vivah Panchami

LOCATED on the lap of great Himalayas, Nepal boasts of rich civilisation, culture and spiritual tradition. As a multicultural, multiethnic, multilingual and multi-religious nation, she has distinct cultural identity that is unity in diversity. Nepal's syncretic culture has fostered harmonious ties among the people from divergent ethnic grounds. Our cultural values inspire the people of different faiths to live in harmony. The rich culture is manifested through religious feasts and festivals, customs, dances and songs. The cultural norms are not rigid so they bear collective values and consciousness. They have been sources of joy and satisfaction. Religion and culture are so deeply interwoven that their bounds are melted into the cultural life of people. Nepal is known as the land of temples where numerous gods and deities are worshipped. The divine figures are the fountain of enlightenment and virtuous deeds. They embody wisdom, knowledge, bravery and compassion.

Godly figures have lived in the memory and tradition of people for millennia. Their moral significance continues to define the societal and familial norms. Lord Ram and Ram's consort Sita have been great sources of ethical values, conduct and acts for Hindus all over the world. They revere and commemorate Ram-Sita on several occasions throughout the years. Ancient philosopher King Janak was the father of Sita and father-in-law of Ram. Every Hindu wants to emulate Ram and Sita in their life. During Vivah Panchami that falls on the fifth day of bright half of Nepali month of Mansir, the people participate in the symbolic marriage of godly couple with devotion and merriment. The wedding celebrations are held in Janakpur, prehistoric city, steeped in Vedic knowledge, myths and tradition.

On Wednesday, the devotees from Nepal and India were engaged in the wedding ceremony of Ram and Sita, fostering the spiritual and cultural bond between Janakpur and Ayodhya of India. During the Treta Yuga, Ram, a prince of Ayodhya, had gone to Janakpur to tie the nuptial knot with Sita. But he had to prove his bravery before wedding Sita. He beat scores of suitors in a bow breaking contest held at Janaki Mandir, the palace of King Janak. The temple has been decorated like a wedding house while the marriage ceremony was held at the Rangabhoomi ground in Janakpurdham. It is believed that all the 560 million deities witnessed the function. According to the news report of this daily, various rituals such as the matkor, tilakotsav and swoyambara were observed as part of a week-long Vivah Panchami. The Province 2 government has granted public holiday for Wednesday across the province to mark the event.

Meanwhile, President Bidya Devi Bhandari has said that Vivah Panchami would help strengthen mutual harmony, tolerance, brotherhood and national unity in the geographically and culturally diverse Nepali society. The people living in the Mithila region have been marking the religious festival since the ancient time. It bears cultural and historical significance in creating a civilised, prosperous and cultured society because the festivals act as unifier among the people from different ethnic and social backgrounds. In addition to its spiritual value, such celebrations also help grow the local economy as it gives momentum to the transaction of goods and services.

Democracy Slides Globally



Mukti Rijal

US President Joe Biden is going to preside over a virtual summit for democracy during these weeks in which the prime minister of Nepal Sher Bahadur Deuba is also invited to speak out to the world leaders. It is reported that more than 100 leaders from across the globe have been invited to the summit. The summit is catapulted, according to the announcement of the US government, to be an occasion to endorse the need to forge a principled commitment to strengthen, renew, and enforce democratic and human rights values across the globe.

Democratic solidarity

The summit for democracy is also claimed to offer an opportunity to strengthen cooperation among democratic actors, institutions and a chance to commit to continue providing global support to democratic and pluralistic political parties and independent civil society organisations. The US expects the democracy summit to lend voice, visibility, and support to individuals and communities across the globe to build and strengthen democratic solidarity.

The state of democracy in the US itself has not been in good form and shape during the contemporary times. Long after Joe Biden assumed the presidency, Freedom House, a democracy-watchdog group ranked the state of democracy in the United States well below that many countries like Chile, Costa Rica, and Slovakia. Freedom House cited gerrymandering, the influence of money in politics, and the disenfranchisement of people of colour among the reasons for the poor showing of the US democracy.

It is against this backdrop that the Biden administration is hosting the virtual Summit for Democracy. When the US president Biden announced the summit during the last August, the goal seemed to be to reestablish America's standing in the world by championing human rights and democratic values. However, a prestigious US newspaper *The Atlantic* writes a critique on the planned summit remarking: "There is something deeply wishful about hosting a summit to bolster democracy around the world when democracy in the US is, at best, floundering. One of the central premises of American exceptionalism is the belief that, against all odds democracy will endure in the US. Yet the paradox at the core of all democracies is that they can be legislated out of existence".

> The COVID-19 pandemic has exacerbated a trend of increasing authoritarianism, across the globe, with many countries sliding down the democratic scale.

It is pertinent to note that International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance, (IDEA) - an inter-governmental organisation based in Stockholm, added the United States to its list of "backsliding" democracies. The US received this label, according to the report issued by the IDEA, in part because of Trump's insistence that the 2020 presidential election in which Joe Biden got elected was fraudulent. In fact, the International IDEA's global state of democracy report 2021 has received more attention and captured a wide discursive space this year in comparison to the similar reports released during the previous years.

The reason behind the spotlight on the report can be attributed in part to the battle cry raised by the Western democracies, especially the US, during these days to promote and reenergise what they call the "democratic values, ideals and norms" and save them from the growing threats of the non-democratic regimes in the world. The threat has been especially noticed and taken cognizance of due to the enhanced resilience and capacity of what the US and its trans-Atlantic partners dub as the nondemocratic regimes to deal with and respond to the global crises and pandemics. Needless to say, China and Russia have succeeded to fight the pandemics and demonstrated the state capacity to deliver.

This has provided a strong rebuttal to the criticisms coming from the Western powers, and vindicated that the political systems that do not conform and align with the Western democracies can be as efficient and effective to deliver development and realise the economic and social aspirations of the people. In fact, the 21st century was hailed optimistically as the century of democracy by the Western powers. The future looked bright, as many erstwhile authoritarian and hybrid regimes, such as Armenia, the Gambia, Malaysia, Myanmar and Tunisia, became democracies. The will of the people as the only legitimate form of authority seemed to be a popular and rapidly spreading ideal. However, the trend seems to have got reversed.

Moreover, the COVID-19 pandemic has exacerbated a trend of increasing authoritarianism, across the globe, with many countries sliding down the democratic scale. Myanmar, which had been a democracy just beginning to recover from decades of military rule, fell victim to a military coup. Significantly, the United States, the bastion of global democracy, fell victim to authoritarian tendencies itself.

As in many other aspects of life, the COVID-19 pandemic has accelerated and magnified pre-existing political trends while adding a whole new plethora of unprecedented challenges to democracies that were already under pressure. Virtually overnight, all democratic systems found themselves dealing with enormous obstacles to hold minimally adequate elections and secure the functioning of legislative and judicial institutions.

Human victory

More importantly, according to the report, executives all over the world felt compelled — and also tempted — to deploy wide-ranging emergency powers to confront the calamity that had befallen the world. The results have been problematic. The monumental human victory achieved when democracy became the predominant form of governance now hangs in the balance like never before, states the global state of democracy report.

Nepal does not find any mention in the global state of democracy report which indicates that the country has not achieved any worthwhile gains in enhancing and strengthening democratic institutions and practices nor has gone backsliding like Myanmar, among others. Nepal should, therefore, improve its democratic scores and profile through reinvigoration of the federal democratic institutions, ethos and practices so that her standing in the democratic world does not go downgraded.

(The author is presently associated with Policy Research Institute (PRI) as a senior research fellow. rijalmukti@gmail.com)

Inequalities Hinder AIDS Elimination



Dr. Tara Nath Pokhrel



Dr. Prajjwal Pyakurel

WORLD AIDS Day was recently marked as an international day to raise awareness on the AIDS pandemic caused by the spread of HIV infection and pay tributes to those who have died of the disease. The acquired immunodeficiency syndrome (AIDS) is a life-threatening condition caused by the human immunodeficiency virus (HIV). The HIV virus attacks the immune system of the patient and reduces resistance to other diseases.

Major barriers

The theme of World AIDS Day 2021 was "End inequalities. End AIDS". Inequality persists everywhere whether be it in prevention, treatment or services. Decades of evidence and experience in HIV research, prevention and treatment has shown that inequalities are the major barriers to achieving the global targets for HIV prevention in 2020. The main reasons behind inequalities are the stigma, discrimination and HIV related criminalisation. These factors enhance people's vulnerability to acquire HIV and make people living with HIV more likely to die of AIDS-related illnesses.

Globally, 37.7 million people were living with HIV in 2020. The new HIV infection was seen in 1.5 million populations with 680,000 people suffered AIDS related death. At the end of December 2020, some 27.5 million people were accessing antiretroviral therapy up from 7.8 million in 2010. New HIV infections have been reduced by 52 per cent since the peak in 1997. AIDS-related deaths have been reduced by 64 per cent since the peak in 2004. The SAARC region has an estimated 2.35 million people living with HIV with India alone bearing an estimated 2.1 million. HIV epidemic in the SAARC Region is a collection of different epidemics in the Member States with their own characteristics and dynamics. In Nepal, HIV prevalence is 0.13 per cent with 790 new infections in 2020. Programming data shows that the clients of sex workers had the major transmissibility of HIV infection (31.6 per cent). Similarly, male population and age group of 25-49 years had the highest number of HIV cases in 2020.

> Support, love, care and strong family and community support are required by the patient of HIV/AIDS to live a normal healthy life.

The international community has committed for ending the AIDS epidemic as a public health threat by 2030, an ambitious target of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development adopted by the United Nations General Assembly in September 2015. However, a gap still remains in various dimensions including seeking, reaching and receiving care. Education, occupation, income, home and community have had direct impact on health and HIV outcome. The lower someone's social and economic status, the poorer their health is likely to be. Additionally, key populations such as gays and others who have sex with men, sex workers, transgender people and those who particularly inject drugs, are subject to discrimination, violence, and crippling legal and social environments. Each of them contributes to HIV vulnerability.

Global AIDS strategy document (2021-2026) prepared by the United Nation Programme on HIV/AIDS (UNAIDS), seeks to reduce inequalities that drive the AIDS epidemic and put people at the centre to get the world on track to end AIDS as a public health threat by 2030. It lays out a framework for transformative action to reduce inequalities by 2025 and to get every country and every community on track to end AIDS by 2030.

Public role is equally important towards the vision of zero new infection, zero discrimination and zero AIDS-related death. Stigma and discrimination are all the outcomes of the societies and the communities and these needs to be wiped out. The attitude of people towards those infected with HIV/AIDS needs to be changed. Support, love, care and strong family and community support are required by the patient of HIV/AIDS to live normal healthy life the society. Additionally, awareness raising campaigns such as information sessions for groups and communities, mobile voluntary counselling and testing and information support for people living with HIV/AIDS need to be carried out

Ambitious goals

We dream of AIDS free world. However, we have to be equally precise to achieve those ambitious goals. All the stakeholders, including the government, public or different organisations and institutions involved in HIV/AIDS prevention should to play their role from their respective sides with honesty, integrity, dedication and commitment. Human values and human right approach should be kept as a priority. Discriminatory laws, rules and policies regarding HIV/AIDs should be addressed besides nullifying stigmas and discriminations. Seeking, reaching and receiving of care for HIV/AIDS should reach each and every corner.

It has been said that whenever AIDS has won stigma, shame, distrust, discrimination and apathy was on its side. Every time AIDS has been defeated because of trust, solidarity and human perseverance through finding new paths and solutions. So, let us join hands and play constructive role from our side to make this world free from AIDS.

(Dr. Pokhrel is Director while Dr. Pyakurel is Research Officer at SAARC Tuberculosis and HIV/AIDS Centre (STAC).)

Plight Of Birds

Devendra Gautam

THE quail farm is a stone's throw from our house compound located in a peri-urban area. For now, let's not talk about whether our competent and responsible authorities should allow the establishment of poultry farms and aviaries at dense settlements, in view of repeated outbreaks of bird flu in the Kathmandu Valley. Talking about cruelty against captive animals and birds will also be an exercise in futility, most probably because there are more pressing matters demanding the attention of authorities.

Equally futile will be any effort to convince the owners of such farms and these competent authorities to invest more in the welfare of captive birds and animals. Advising owners of such farms to switch to, say, herb/vegetable farming may not yield desired results. And don't even dare to explain Einsteinian pain waves to these parties if you have not 'lost your mind'. Nonetheless, let's hope and pray that it won't take another bird flu outbreak for our 'competent' authorities to realise the risks associated with poultry farming in densely populated urban areas.

Back to the quail farm. In rarest of the rare cases, quails fly to our house compound from that farm -- perhaps during feeding/cleaning time. On one such occasion, I happened to find a beautiful quail struggling to liberate itself from the confines of our compound. Apparently, this confinement was no better for the bird that wanted to test limitless freedom once again. Without much thought, I informed the farm owner and the bird again landed in captivity. There, like other birds, it must have been forced to keep breeding and breeding throughout its productive life. In the end, I think, it was sold and slaughtered for meat.

To this date, I regret informing the farm owner about that 'rebellious' bird. Instead, I should have caught it somehow and released it into the jungle. The bird wanted freedom and death is what I gave!

A few days ago, another captive bird took the same course. It flew into our compound from the farm, as per my family members. I came to know that this bird was stuck somewhere in the shoe rack and struggling to free itself. To my surprise, the bird was nowhere to be seen when I went about searching for it.

Perhaps the neighbourhood cat pounced on it, the farm owner got hold of it or some mischievous kid took it away. But that is not the end of possible 'fates' for the bird. Perhaps the bird managed to overcome the obstacles to the boundless freedom it had always aspired for. After several desperate attempts and bodily injuries, the bird may have managed to free itself from the confines of our compound marked by high walls and iron railings.

As per ancient scriptures, liberation from the cycle of birth and death is a long and hard journey. Our deeds determine what form we will be born into from among 8,400, 000 lives! That's a lot of lives to choose from, isn't it? The point to be noted is that not all organisms live for years like humans do. Insects, for example, have a very short lifespan.

To me, the white bird embodies the soul. Our scriptures point that the body is like a hotel room and the soul is a guest. As you know, the guests keep changing. With my mind's eye, I see a white bird soaring higher and higher in its quest for limitless freedom after overcoming human-made walls, railings and trappings. While I feel happy for that particular bird, profound sadness envelopes my heart when I think about the plight of captive birds.

50 Years Ago

December 9, 1971

Farewell Reception

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu

The Royal Nepalese Consulate General designate to Dacca, Mr. Madhab Kumar Rimal held a farewell reception on the eve of his departure for Dacca.

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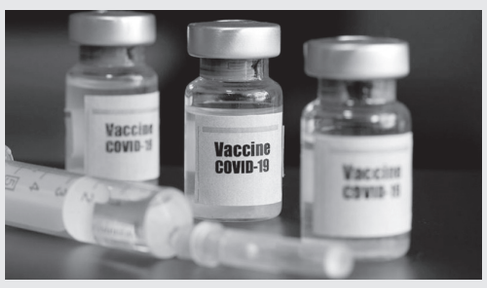
Reader's Mail

Intensify Vaccination Against COVID-19

I am writing this in reference to the news report titled *'Dhanusa to vaccinate all aged above 18 from December 10',* which appeared in your daily on December 8.

As COVID-19 continues its destruction throughout the world, it has become important to contain the pandemic. As such, vaccination drive needs to be amped up. Nepal is doing remarkably well with vaccinating its citizens. The daily infections are slowing down as well.

However, the new coronavirus variant called 'Omicron' is posing a threat worldwide which is why Nepal must strengthen its checkpoints in the borders between Nepal and India. With the support from generous nations and global organisations, the country has been able to vaccinate its citizens and as a result the cases have decreased. Still, the nation must remain vigilant when it comes to curbing the contagion. The fact that districts of Nepal are carrying out vaccination drives steadily is certainly welcome news. At present, the government is inoculating some



200,000 people on a daily basis.

As the World Health Organisation (WHO) has stated that the existing COVID-19 vaccines are effective in containing even the Omicron variant. This news has brought a lot of cheers to people around the world. However, everybody must abide by all the health safety rules to remain safe from the risk of this deadly viral disease.

Nabina Mahato
Gaushala, Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

An artist asked the gallery owner if there had been any interest in her paintings that were on display.

"Well, I have good news and bad news," the owner responded. "The good news is that a gentleman noticed your work and wondered if it would appreciate in value after your death. I told him it would and he bought all 10 of your paintings."

"That's wonderful," the artist exclaimed. "What's the bad news?"

"The gentleman was your doctor."

A blonde was driving down the motorway when she read a sign saying, "Clean toilets ahead, 10 miles on the left."

She was really late for her appointment since there were 26 toilets to clean.



A video aired late Tuesday, Dec. 7, 2021 by broadcaster ITV showed then-press secretary of Britain Allegra Stratton appearing to joke about an illicit party at the prime minister's Downing Street office. (File Photo: AP)

WORLD

Biden-Putin talks yield no breakthrough

AP
Washington , Dec. 8

US President Joe Biden and Vladimir Putin were still far apart after two hours of talks on the escalating crisis caused by Russia's massing of tens of thousands of troops near its border with Ukraine.

Biden delivered a simple message during Tuesday's video call with Putin: invade Ukraine again and face painful sanctions that will do resounding harm to your economy. Putin had his own blunt take, according to his foreign adviser Yuri Ushakov, telling the U.S. president that "the Russian troops are on their own territory, and they don't threaten anyone."

With no immediate breakthrough to ease tensions on the Ukraine question, the U.S. emphasized a need for diplomacy and de-escalation, while issuing stern threats to Russia about the high costs of a military incursion.

Biden "told President Putin directly that if Russia further invades Ukraine, the United States and our European allies would respond with strong economic measures," U.S. National Security Adviser Jake Sullivan said. He added that Biden said the U.S. would also "provide additional defensive material to the Ukrainians … and we would fortify our NATO allies on the eastern flank with additional capabilities in response to such an escalation."

White House officials made clear that Biden is not interested in putting U.S. troops in harm's way defending Ukraine. But Sullivan added that potential efforts to bolster regional allies could lead to additional deployments of U.S. troops to eastern European NATO allies.

A top U.S. envoy, Victoria Nuland, said a Russian invasion of Ukraine would also jeopardize a controversial pipeline between Russia and Germany known as Nord Stream 2. She told the Senate Foreign Relations Committee on Tuesday that if Russia invaded, "our expectation is that the pipeline will be suspended."



US President Joe Biden speaks as he meets virtually via a secure video conference with Russian President Vladimir Putin from the Situation Room at the White House in Washington. (Photo: AP)

Ushakov dismissed the sanctions threat during his own comments to reporters following the leaders' meeting.

"While the U.S. president talked about possible sanctions, our president emphasized what Russia needs," Ushakov said. "Sanctions aren't something new, they have been in place for a long time and will not have any effect."

He described the presidents' video conference as "candid and businesslike," adding that they also exchanged occasional jokes.

The two leaders met on the 80th anniversary of the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbour, a defining moment that led to the U.S. entry in World War II. They commiserated about the cost of that conflict to their own families, Ushakov noted. Hours before the high-stakes call, Biden and first lady Jill Biden visited a war memorial in Washington to commemorate the solemn anniversary.

In a brief snippet of the start of their meeting broadcasted by Russian state television, the two leaders offered friendly greetings to each other.

"I welcome you, Mr. President," Putin said, speaking with a Russian flag behind him and a video monitor showing Biden in front of him.

At the White House, Sullivan called it "a useful meeting," allowing Biden to lay out in candid terms where America stands.

But as the U.S. and Russian presidents conferred, Ukraine grew only more anxious about the tens of thousands of Russian troops that have been deployed near its border.

Ukrainian officials said Russia had further escalated the crisis by sending tanks and snipers to war-torn eastern Ukraine to "provoke return fire" and lay a pretext for a potential invasion.

U.S. intelligence officials have not been able to independently verify that accusation, according to an administration official who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss the sensitive matter.

But the official said that the White House has directly raised concerns with the Russians about "resorting to their old playbook" by trying to provoke the Ukrainians.

Putin entered the call looking for guarantees from Biden that an expansion of the NATO military alliance would never include Ukraine, a demand that was a non-starter for the U.S. and its NATO allies.

The Kremlin, in a post-call statement, said NATO had been "making dangerous attempts to expand its presence on the Ukrainian territory and has been expanding its military potential near Russian borders."

On another matter, Putin proposed to lift all mutual restrictions on diplomatic missions and help normalize other aspects of bilateral relations, according to the Kremlin. Sullivan said the leaders would direct their staff to continue negotiations on that.

The leader-to-leader conversation — Biden speaking from the White House Situation Room, Putin from his residence in Sochi — was one of the most important of Biden's presidency and came at a perilous time.

U.S. intelligence officials have determined that Russia has moved 70,000 troops near the Ukraine border and has made preparations for a possible invasion early next year.

Sullivan said the U.S. believes that Putin has not yet made a final decision to invade. Biden was vice president in 2014 when Russian troops strode into the Black Sea peninsula of Crimea and annexed the territory from Ukraine.

Aides say the Crimea episode — one of the darker moments for then-President Barack Obama on the international stage — looms large as Biden looks at the smouldering current crisis.

Biden's Republican opponents in Washington are framing this moment as a key test of the president's leadership on the global stage. Biden vowed as a candidate to reassert American leadership after President Donald Trump's emphasis on an "America First" foreign policy.

"I will look you in the eye and tell you as President Biden looked President Putin in the eye and told him today that things we did not do in 2014, we are prepared to do now," Sullivan told reporters after the leaders' video call.

Republicans have charged that Biden has been ineffective in slowing Iran's march toward becoming a nuclear power and has done too little to counter autocratic leaders including China's Xi Jinping and Putin.

Scholz succeeds Merkel as German chancellor

AP
Berlin, Dec. 8



Olaf Scholz of the Social Democrats reacts after he was elected new German Chancellor in the German Parliament Bundestag in Berlin, Wednesday, Dec. 8, 2021. (Photo: AP)

Olaf Scholz became Germany's ninth post-World War II chancellor Wednesday, opening a new era for the European Union's most populous nation and largest economy after Angela Merkel's 16-year tenure.

Scholz's government takes office with high hopes of modernizing Germany and combating climate change but faces the immediate challenge of handling the country's toughest phase yet of the coronavirus pandemic.

Lawmakers voted by 395-303 to elect Scholz, with six abstentions — a comfortable majority, though short of the 416 seats his three-party coalition holds in the 736-seat lower house of parliament. That's not unusual when chancellors are elected, and some lawmakers were out sick.

Scholz exchanged fist bumps with lawmakers from across the political spectrum before German President Frank-Walter Steinmeier formally appointed him as chancellor. He was due to be sworn in by the speaker of parliament later Wednesday.

Merkel, who is no longer a member of parliament, looked on from the spectators' gallery as parliament voted. Lawmakers gave her a standing ovation as the session started.

Scholz, 63, Germany's vice chancellor and finance minister since 2018, brings a wealth of experience and discipline to an untried coalition of his centre-left Social Democrats, the environmentalist Greens and the pro-business Free Democrats. The three parties are portraying the combination of former rivals as a progressive alliance that will bring new energy to the country after Merkel's near-record time in office.

The new government aims to step up efforts against climate change by expanding the use of renewable energy and bringing Germany's exit from coal-fired power forward from 2038, "ideally" to 2030. It also wants to do more to modernize the country, including improving its notoriously poor cellphone and internet networks.

It also plans more liberal social policies, including legalizing the sale of cannabis for recreational purposes and easing the path to German citizenship while pledging greater efforts to deport immigrants who don't win asylum. The coalition partners want to lower the voting age in national elections from 18 to 16.

'Omicron no worse than other virus variants'

AFP
Geneva, Dec. 8

The Omicron variant appears to be no worse than other coronavirus strains, top scientists from the WHO and the United States told AFP, while cautioning that more research is needed to judge its severity. The hopeful assessments came as global concern grew over the heavily mutated variant, which has forced dozens of nations to re-impose border restrictions and raised the possibility of a return of economically punishing lockdowns. While it is likely more transmissible than previous variants, Omicron is also "highly unlikely" to completely evade vaccine protections, the World Health Organization's second-in-command told AFP on Tuesday.

"The preliminary data doesn't indicate that this is more severe. In fact, if anything, the direction is towards less severity," WHO emergencies director Michael Ryan said in an interview, insisting though that more research was needed.

Ryan also said there was no sign that Omicron could fully sidestep protections provided by existing Covid vaccines."We have highly effective vaccines that have proved effective against all the variants so far, in terms of severe disease and hospitalisation...

There's no reason to expect that it wouldn't be so" for Omicron, he added, pointing to initial data from South Africa, where the strain was first reported. However, Ryan acknowledged that it was possible that existing vaccines might prove less effective against Omicron, which counts more than 30 mutations on the spike protein that dots the surface of the coronavirus and allows it to invade cells.

Top US scientist Anthony Fauci echoed the WHO's view, saying Omicron did not appear worse than prior strains based on early indications -- and was possibly milder. The new variant is "clearly highly transmissible," very likely more so than Delta, the current dominant global strain, Fauci told AFP.

Myanmar democracy in new era as Suu Kyi sidelined

AP
Bangkok, Dec. 8

In sentencing Myanmar's iconic democracy leader Aung San Suu Kyi to prison, the country's generals have effectively exiled her from electoral politics. But that doesn't mean the Southeast Asian nation is back to square one in its stop-start efforts to move toward democracy.

In fact, a younger generation that came of age as the military began loosening its grip on politics and the economy and has tasted some freedoms is well positioned to carry on the struggle.

A de facto coup on Feb. 1 pushed Suu Kyi's elected government from power, throwing the country into turmoil. But erasing the gains of a decade of opening up has proved more difficult.

People took to the streets en masse almost immediately and have continued sporadic protests since then. As a military crackdown on demonstrations grew increasingly violent, protesters moved to arm themselves.



Protesters hold portraits of deposed Myanmar leader Aung San Suu Kyi during an anti-coup demonstration in Mandalay, Myanmar on March 5, 2021. (Photo: AP)

Within days, a mix of old and new guard, including elected lawmakers who were prevented from taking their seats by the takeover, announced a shadow administration that declared itself the nation's only legitimate government. It was very consciously assembled to be a diverse group, including representatives of ethnic minorities and one openly gay member, unusual in socially conservative Myanmar.

It, not Suu Kyi, who was arrested in the takeover, has been at the forefront of the opposition — and has garnered significant support among the general population.

PRISM

Goat steals official papers from government office in India

Kanpur: A goat entered a government office in India and was caught on video walking off with a file full of papers from inside the building.

The video, filmed outside the Panchayat Secretary office in Chaubepur, Kanpur, shows an employee chasing after the goat while it holds a file of papers in its mouth.

Witnesses said the goat had entered the building while employees were working outside and walked off with papers from an office where documents related to village development projects are stored.

Chaubepur Block Development Officer Manulal Yadav said the file carried away by the goat only contained scrap papers, and not official documents.

The employees recovered most of the papers from the animal, but some had been chewed up.

Yadav said employees have now been instructed to remain inside the office while working.

Police chase loose camel through Kansas city

Kansas: Police in Kansas said they spent "the entire day" Sunday chasing an escaped camel that trotted across a golf course, ran down a highway and visited a few neighbourhoods.

The Bonner Springs Police Department said officers and animal control personnel responded Sunday when a loose camel was spotted running loose in the city.

"This morning, officers took to the golf courses in pursuit of the camel (on golf carts no less)," the department said in a Facebook post. "Later, it took a leisurely jaunt down K-7 Highway and into some neighbourhoods."

Police said they "spent the entire day" chasing after the camel before it was finally captured with a lasso.

"The camel was reunited with its owners and will go back to doing camel things," the post said.

(Agencies)

Today in History

480 – Odoacer, first King of Italy, occupies Dalmatia. He later establishes his political power with the co-operation of the Roman Senate.
1856 – The Iranian city of Bushehr surrenders to occupying British forces.
1861 – American Civil War: The Joint Committee on the Conduct of the War is established by the U.S. Congress.
1868 – The first traffic lights are installed, outside the Palace of Westminster in London. Resembling railway signals, they use semaphore arms and are illuminated at night by red and green gas lamps.
1872 – In Louisiana, P. B. S. Pinchback becomes the first African-American governor of a U.S. state.

Source: www.wikipedia.org

Test feeding plan in works for starving manatees

AP
St. Petersburg, Fla., Dec. 8

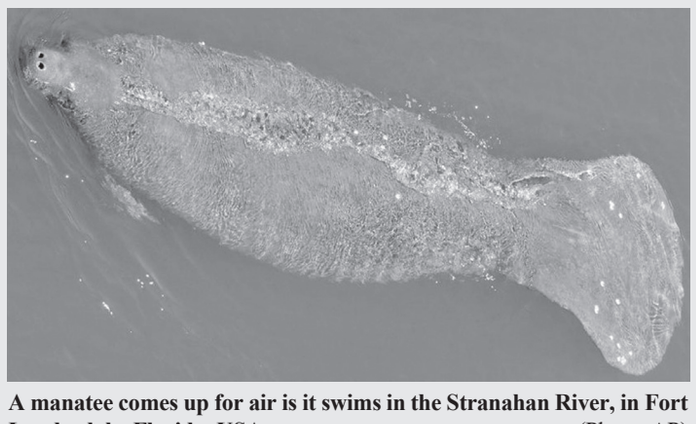
Normally giving food to wild animals is considered off limits, but the dire situation in Florida with more than 1,000 manatees dying from starvation due to manmade pollution is leading officials to consider an unprecedented feeding plan.

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service and state environmental officials intend to unveil a limited proposal this week to feed the beloved marine mammals in one specific Florida location to test how it works. This is not usually done with any wild animal, but the situation has become such an emergency that it has to be considered, said Save The Manatee Club Executive Director Patrick Rose.

The club was co-founded in 1981 by Florida troubadour Jimmy Buffet and former governor and U.S. Sen. Bob Graham.

A Fish and Wildlife Service spokesman said in an email that the agency "does have approval to move forward on a limited feeding trial" but that details are not yet finalized. A formal announcement is expected later this week.

The emerging plan would involve feeding manatees at a Florida Power & Light plant in Cape Canaveral, along the Indian River Lagoon on the east coast where manatees congregate in cold winter months because of the warm water discharge from the plant. It would be an experiment involving lettuce, cabbage, and other greens delivered in a controlled manner such as via a conveyer belt, Rose said.



A manatee comes up for air is it swims in the Stranahan River, in Fort Lauderdale, Florida, USA. (Photo: AP)

People would not be authorized to simply start tossing lettuce into a Florida bay some place.

"Under no circumstances do we want people feeding manatees. It's illegal, and remains so," Rose said.

Manatees have long struggled to survive with humans. Hundreds of the slow-moving animals are struck every year by boats, which has led to no-wake manatee zones throughout Florida with violations punishable by significant fines. But the starvation threat has led to a record 1,017 manatee deaths as of Nov. 19, according to state figures.

Postage stamp portraying Rastrakabi unveiled

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Gyanendra Bahadur Karki Wednesday released a commemorative postage stamp of the Rastrakabi, late Madhav Prasad Ghimire.

Unveiling the first postage stamp of late Ghimire at a function held at the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology on Wednesday, Minister Karki said that the government had decided to issue the postage stamp honouring Ghimire's unmated contribution to Nepali literature. The Department of Postal Services under the Ministry issued the postage stamp of Rs. 10 in memory of late Ghimire.

'Pay traffic fine on the spot system' from today

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

Metropolitan Traffic Police Division, Ramshahpath, is all set to begin on the spot online traffic violation fine system from Thursday.

Any traffic rule violator, who comes under the scrutiny of the traffic police, can pay their fine immediately from the spot where they are caught for breaching the rules, Senior Superintendent of Police (SSP) Janak Bhattarai said.

Everyone has a role to play in safeguarding human rights: VP

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

Vice President Nanda Bahadur Pun has said that every citizen has a role to play in safeguarding human rights.

Speaking at the inauguration ceremony of week-long programmes on human rights organised by Megha Meet Committee on Wednesday, the Vice President urged the political parties and the government to conclude the peace process soon.

Despite being signatory to several international conventions, Nepal has not performed as per its obligations, he said.

He said that Nepal had yet to ensure the fundamental rights to all citizens.

The conclusion of Megha Meet would be supportive to ensure the human rights, he added.

No sector, community, group or individual should be left behind in case of human rights, said Top Bahadur Magar, chairman of the National Human Rights Commission.

The Megha Meet, which was organised on the occasion 73rd International Human Rights Day, will be a milestone in terms of protecting human rights, he said.



Vice President Nanda Bahadur Pun inaugurating a function organised to mark the 73rd International Human Rights Day in the capital on Wednesday. *(Photo: Kabita Thapa/TRN)*

Roshan Khadka, Coordinator of National Human Rights Megha Meet, urged all organisations, civil society and individual to participate in the programme.

At the programme, Krishna Prasad Bhandari, Advocate and human rights activist, and Bhadra Man Ghale were honoured with the appreciation letter of Human Rights National Megha Meet-2077.

Dr. Renu Adhikari and Daman Nath Dhungana were honoured with the title of Padma Ratna Tuladhar National Human Rights and Peace Prize-2077/78.

Muskan Khatun and Sapana Roka Magar were presented Santi Laxmi Women Human Rights Award of 2077/78.

280 new COVID cases recorded, 366 patients recover

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

The Ministry of Health and Population (MoHP) on Wednesday confirmed 280 new cases of COVID-19. Of them, 255 were detected through Real-Time Polymerase Chain Reaction (RT-PCR) tests, and 25 were detected through antigen tests.



The nationwide COVID-19 tally through the RT-PCR method has reached 823,357 and that through antigen tests reached 95,687.

Of the total 12,174 tests conducted in the last 24 hours, 9,168 were Real-Time Polymerase Chain Reaction (RT-PCR) while 3,006 were antigen tests, informed the MoHP.

According to the MoHP, the Kathmandu Valley recorded 146 new infections over the same period. Of these, 100 cases were confirmed in Kathmandu, 15 in Bhaktapur, and 31 in Lalitpur.

In the past 24 hours, 24 new infections were recorded in Province 1, two in Province 2, 195 in Bagmati Province, 19 in Gandaki Province, 10 in Lumbini Province and five in Karnali Province. Sudurpaschim Province did not report any new cases of COVID-19 in the past 24 hours.

As per the MoHP's data, only Kathmandu and Lalitpur districts have more than 500 active cases and six other districts have more than 200 active cases each. Moreover, Manang, Mustang, Dolpa, Humla, and Salyan are the districts with zero active cases.

Similarly, the COVID-19 active caseload has reached 6,339 on Wednesday. Of the active cases, 326 patients are admitted to various health facilities while the remaining 5,913 are in home isolation.

As per the latest update, 128 COVID-19 patients are admitted to the Intensive Care Units (ICUs) while 29 are under treatment with ventilator support throughout the nation.

Meanwhile, 366 COVID-19 patients recovered from the infection in the last 24 hours. Nepal has now recorded 805,571 cases of recovery.

The nation reported two COVID-19 related fatalities on Wednesday. Currently the COVID-19 death toll is at 11,5457. The recovery rate of the novel coronavirus has reached 97.8 per cent and the death rate is 1.4 per cent.

'Nepal's post-quake ...

European Commissioner for Crisis Management, Janez Lenarcic, said that the European Union had supported Nepal in training the human resources for building back better and provided engineering support to the government.

Meaningful partnership

World Bank's Country Director for Nepal, the Maldives and Sri Lanka, Faris H. Hadad-Zervos, said that there was a remarkable progress in reconstruction in private houses, schools, health facilities.

"This was possible through the effective partnership among the government agencies and international organisations," he said.

Vice President of the Asian Development Bank, Shixin Chen, UNICEF's Regional Director for South Asia George Laryea-Adjei, and Director General of SDC, Patricia Danzi congratulated Nepal and suggested to promote resilience in public and private construction.

The international delegates said that resilience has been built in the past six years since the devastating Gorkha Earthquake 2015. They also suggested to strengthen the local governments in terms of disaster management and relief operations.

President Bhandari stresses on resilient structures

President Bidya Devi Bhandari said that Nepal will develop all physical structures and infrastructures strong enough to endure any disaster. "The quake has taught us an important lesson in terms of disaster preparedness and resilience, so we must not forget the lessons it taught us," she said while speaking at the inaugural session of the ICNR 2021.

According to her, the damage and loss in the quake was primarily because of the weak infrastructure, and creating resilient infrastructure can lower the risk during the disasters.

President Bhandari appreciated the courage of Nepali people and their support in the rescue, relief and reconstruction drive.

"The reconstruction work was a massive task amidst limited resources, complex geographical condition and state restructuring process. However, meaningful cooperation among the national and international agencies and support of people led the reconstruction campaign to success," she said.

She appreciated all national and international partners, donors and agencies which extended their support to the reconstruction process.

The first ICNR in 2015 had drawn the pledges of Rs. 425 billion for post-quake relief and reconstruction. However, actual pledge stood only at Rs. 325 billion.

"We can now proudly say that the people at the epicentre, Barpak, and all affected areas have returned to their own houses while the historical structures like Dharahara, Ranipokhari and Durbar High School have been resurrected with more beauty and resilience," stated President Bhandari.

Minister for Foreign Affairs Dr. Narayan Khadka thanked all donors and supporters. "About US$ 4.9 billion was estimated for the post-quake reconstruction which was beyond the capacity of the government. International community came forth to offer us the much-required support for the reconstruction and rehabilitation," he said.

Minister for Finance Janardan Sharma said that the government had moved ahead with the policy of integrated settlements in safer locations.

The government had established the NRA on 25 December 2015 and the national reconstruction campaign was launched in January 2016.

The NRA has completed the basic reconstruction and rehabilitation works of infrastructures damaged on April 25, 2015 earthquake during almost six years of its establishment and has already handed over the responsibility of remaining works to concerned ministries, departments and agencies, read a statement issued by it in October.

I has handed over the remaining works to the concerned government agencies.

The three-day conference is being organised to share Nepal's learning and experiences with national and international communities and is being organised with the slogan of – "From Reconstruction to Resilience".

The conference also aims at strengthening relationship between government and multilateral agencies, bilateral agencies and civil society considering the way forward on resilient Nepal, and inform the government about the disaster-related laws and policies.

NC leaders...

Paudel faction loyal NC newly-elected district presidents and former presidents also asked the leaders to forge consensus.

Ghimire said the next meeting of the group would be held on Thursday. In the meeting, exhibiting frustration, leader Paudel said if consensus eluded four leaders, he would take retirement from the party. "If all of us contest and do not forge consensus I will desert the party," he said.

Consensus for party president has become difficult in Paudel faction as Singh and Dr. Shekhar Koirala remained adamant to their claim. However, Paudel and Dr. Shashank had already told that they were ready to give up their claim for consensus.

The other faction led by leader Krishna Prasad Sitaula also held discussion to make strategies.

After a meeting held between Paudel and Sitaula, the faction led by latter held a separate meeting.

4319 voters

Meanwhile, the NC has made public the preliminary list of delegates for the 14th general convention. In the preliminary list that was made public by the Central Election Committee on Tuesday, 4319 delegates are elected for general convention.

The party has scheduled to begin its general convention on December 10 in Kathmandu. The code of conduct for general convention has been published as well.

Meanwhile, a code of conduct for the general convention was made public also on Wednesday.

CWC meeting today

The party has called its CWC meeting on Thursday.

NC chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel informed that the meeting would take necessary decisions for the 14th general convention preparation.

'Make Nepali products...

"However, the domestic products can be made qualitative and competitive." He said that both the government and businessmen should pay attention to this.

Minister Sharma said that though it was not possible to compete in everything, it was necessary to make certain selected items competitive.

He said that the food industry as well as various other sectors should be selected to make the country self-reliant and competitive in special products.

For that, the traditional policy needs to be changed in a timely manner and that is possible, he said.

Minister Sharma also urged the entrepreneurs to make additional contributions by converting the contribution of the automobile sector into the industrial sector.

He urged to change the revenue contribution based on customs by establishing a four-wheeler manufacturing industry in Nepal.

FM Sharma also committed to provide services to be provided by the government for production, concession on electricity tariff and land management.

He said that there is potential not only for vehicle production but also for various industries, including tyres, lubricants and batteries.

Minister Sharma also urged the automobile entrepreneurs to suggest policies for making such industries self-reliant and necessary reforms.

Petrol pumps should convert into charging stations

He said that petrol pumps should now be converted into charging stations.

He said that the use of electric vehicles should be increased to reduce petrol consumption and environmental pollution in the country.

"Now petrol pumps should be gradually converted into charging stations," Sharma said. That fact must be taken into account."

On the occasion, Senior Vice President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) Chandra Prasad Dhakal urged to make the traditional policy rules timely for rapid economic progress and development of the country.

Changing the traditional policy rules would benefit the people and achieve the government's goal of economic transformation.

"It's not just about the automobile sector. It is in the interest of all parties to change the old policy and rules by holding discussions with the stakeholders on the suggestions of the private sector as a whole," he said. For this, the state should take the lead."

The annual general meeting will elect a new executive committee of NADA.

Valley hospitals...

TU Teaching Hospital

Dr. Ram Bikram Adhikari, information officer at the hospital, said that the hospital was well-equipped to treat 500 to 600 COVID-19 patients at once.

"We have learnt a lot from the second wave. Thus, we are already in a position to deal with the new variant or the possible third wave," said Dr. Adhikari, adding that a total of 50 HDU beds were available in the hospital.

He further said that the hospital had installed oxygen plant which can produce 2,000 litres of oxygen in a minute.

Bir Hospital

Dr. Bhupendra Basnet, chief of Bir Hospital, said that the hospital had introduced telemedicine service for the treatment of COVID-19 patients. "We have set aside 209 beds for COVID-19 patients in case the virus spreads rapidly," he said. The hospital is equipped with 100 ICUs and HDU beds, said Dr. Basnet, adding that the hospital would not face shortage of oxygen again. Currently, the hospital has an oxygen plant with 250 litres capacity.

Sukraraj Tropical and Infectious Disease Hospital

The COVID-19-dedicated hospital has already issued an alert and provided training to the health workers and staffers regarding the new variant, said director Dr. Rawal.

She added that the hospital resumed the operation of vaccine clinic from Sunday. There are 24 ICUs, a COVID-19 isolation ward and an oxygen plant with over 20,000 litres capacity at Teku Hospital.

Meanwhile, the MoHP has informed that it has been making efforts to minimise the risk of Omicron in Nepal.

Dr. Samir Kumar Adhikari, assistant spokesperson at the ministry, said, "Following the detection of Omicron in Nepal, we have been conducting the monitoring, surveillance and contact tracing more effectively."

"Managing the flow of people into and out of the nation via international flights and borders, we have made negative RT-PCR test report compulsory," he said.

"Antigen tests are being performed on entrants who have not received the full dose of COVID-19 vaccines and those having the symptoms of the virus infection," said Dr. Adhikari, adding, "Furthermore, RT-PCR tests and gene sequencing of antigen positive samples are also being done."

India's...

Defense Minister Rajnath Singh said Rawat "served the country with exceptional courage and diligence." The air force said an inquiry has been ordered into the accident.

Rawat, 63, was the most senior official in the Indian military and the first chief of defense staff, a position created by the government in 2019. He was also an adviser to the Defense Ministry and handles coordination and integration of the combat capabilities of the armed forces.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Communication and Information Technology
Security Printing Development Committee
Security Printing Center
Singhadurbar, Kathmandu

Issuance of letter of intent to award the contract

This is to notify that, it is our intention to award the contract for execution of the procurement of Construction of Multipurpose Building at Security Printing Center, Contract identification Number: SPC/WORKS/NCB/01/078-79 to Samanantar-Rabina-Himalayan JV, KMC-09, Old Baneshwor Kathmandu as bid price NRs. Nepalese Rupees **397,011,094.23** (three hundred ninety seven million eleven thousand ninety four and Paisa twenty three as corrected and modified in accordance with the instructions to Bidders is here by selected as substantially responsive lowest evaluated bid.

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Communication and Information Technology
National Information Technology Center
Singhadurbar, Kathmandu

Addendum Notice No. 2

2078/8/23 (December 09, 2021)

This is to notify all concerned that Ministry of Communication and Information Technology, National Information Technology Center, Singhadurbar, Kathmandu, has made the following amendment to the Bidding Document for the **Supply, Delivery, Installation and Commissioning of Diesel Generator and Electromechanical Equipment,** IFB No.: NITC/G/NCB-8/078-79 as per the notice published on Kartik 28, 2078 (November 14, 2021) in the daily "The Rising Nepal" national daily newspaper.

S. N.	Reference of Bid Document	Tender Clause Description	Amendments
1	Section II. Bid Data Sheet, C. Preparation of Bids, ITB 21.1	The bid must be accompanied by bid security, amounting to a minimum of NRs. 2,00,000.00 (Two Lakh Only) which shall be valid 30 days beyond the bid validity period.	**The phrase has been amended to:** The bid must be accompanied by bid security, amounting to a minimum of NRs. 35,00,000.00 (Thirty Five Lakh Only) which shall be valid 30 days beyond the bid validity period.

Limbu music videos to preserve Limbu culture

By Our Correspondent
Panchthar, Dec. 8



Most of the music videos are entertainment-oriented.

However, a few Limbu youth are making music videos to save their culture while entertaining the listeners.

Ravi Sherma, Sagar Kerung, Mausam Imbung, Loken Saawa, Buddha Raj Limbu and Dinesh Mangmu have directed many such videos with the sole aim of preserving the limbu culture.

They have a common saying, "Showing our civilisation is first priority in our videos."

All the music videos of the Limbu songs show the glimpses of the Limbu civilisation, culture and lifestyle.

Their videos mostly portray Limbus' history, religion, jewelry, traditional dresses, rituals, professions, myth, mundhum and folk rhythm.

In the past, culture-oriented music videos did not succeed in the commercial market. Recently, development of social networks like Facebook and YouTube has helped massively in marketing their products.

Therefore, in terms of income, Limbu music videos are becoming a good possibility, said filmmaker Mitra Lingden.

Limbu artistes are equally fascinated by singing Limbu songs and appearing in the videos.

Model and actress Sukmita Kerung said that they did the videos thinking that it was their responsibility to preserve their culture and civilisation.

Dozens of music videos depicting the Limbu culture have been made. Several others are in the process of being formed.

Director Sagar Kerung said that two dozen Limbu music videos were produced in the last one and a half months alone.

Music videos consisting of Limbu songs like Chitangsir, Hilik-Hilik, Chuichui Ha and Mawa Yanghang have recently hit the market.

Many music videos are being produced in the Limbu-dominated settlements of Panchthar. They are also being made in Taplejung, Tehrathum, Ilam, Sunsari and Kathmandu.

Rihanna, Beyoncé, and Taylor Swift are the most powerful women in music



Agencies
New York, Dec. 8

Singers Rihanna, Beyoncé, and Taylor Swift are among Forbes' top 100 list of the world's most powerful women in 2021.

On Tuesday (7 December), Forbes released its annual list and a total of 15 women from media and entertainment were honoured.

Rihanna, who was recently named National Hero of the newly founded republic of Barbados, came in at No 68 on the list.

Forbes also revealed the "Diamonds" singer is now a billionaire, courtesy the success of her Fenty Beauty cosmetics line.

Co-owned by French luxury retailer LVMH, the beauty brand raked in over $550m (approximately £415m) in revenue in 2020.

"Single Ladies" singer Beyoncé was listed at No 76 on the Forbes list. The business magazine credited the former Destiny's Child singer with pulling in a total of $250m (approximately £189m) over the course of her On The Run II stadium tour with billionaire husband Jay Z.

The multi-hyphenate also announced a global partnership deal between her athleisure clothing brand Ivy Park and Adidas in 2019.

She teased the first look of their fifth collaborative collection Halls of Ivy on Instagram last week. The campaign features celebrity children, including Reese Witherspoon's son Deacon Phillipe and daughter Ava Phillipe, and the late Kobe Bryant's daughter Natalia.

Landing at spot No 78, Swift has smashed multiple music records this year.

Her 2020 album Folklore became the pandemic year's first album to sell one million units.

The singer's compilation of re-released music Red (Taylor's Version) became the singer's 10th album to reach No 1 on the Billboard 200.

Further, her 10-minute song from the overhauled Red, "All Too Well" became the longest song to ever reach No 1 on the Billboard Hot 100 US list.

Meanwhile, Oprah Winfrey's estimated total net worth of $2.6bn (approximately £1.7bn) catapulted her to the No 23 spot on Forbes's list, as the philanthropist, talk show host and media mogul was crowned the most powerful woman in media and entertainment this year.

Actor Reese Witherspoon was at the No 74 spot, after her women-driven content company Hello Sunshine was acquired in August this year, at an estimated value of $900m (£679m).

The top spot went to author, philanthropist and Amazon founder Jeff Bezos's former wife, MacKenzie Scott with an estimated net worth of $59.2bn (approximately £44.6bn) and 25% stake in the e-commerce giant.

Weightlifter's story in music video

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

Story of Sharad Poudyal's struggle and success in weightlifting after losing his left leg in the 2015 earthquake has been presented in the song Uthna Sakina, Himmat Nahare.

A video of the song with Pushpan Pradhan's voice and music was made public on Tuesday.

The video of the song with lyrics by lyricist Dinesh Adhikari is directed by Surendra Singh Nepali.

The music video features Nirajan Pradhan and Rubina Thapa. It was shot by Babu Shrestha while Renish Phago has done colour work and Bhupendra Adhikari has edited it.

The music video conveys the inspiring message that one should not lose courage even in a critical situation.

The true story-based music video was produced by Samjhana Singh Nepali.

Director Nepali informed that both the song and video are getting good responses from audience.

He said that the message of living and doing something for society is conveyed to people through the song.

Closing arguments set in actor Jussie Smollett's trial

AP
Chicago, Dec. 8

Closing arguments are scheduled for Wednesday morning in the case against former "Empire" actor Jussie Smollett, who is accused of staging a racist, anti-gay attack against himself in downtown Chicago to get publicity.

The jury is then expected to begin deliberating whether Smollett is guilty on six counts of a low-level felony for lying to Chicago police about the January 2019 attack.

Taking the witness stand earlier this week, Smollett repeatedly denied the attack was a fake, telling a prosecutor "there was no hoax on my part" and that two brothers who testified against him are "liars."

Smollett called the Osundairo brothers' testimony that he paid them $3,500 to carry out the fake attack "100% false," and described how he was the victim of a hate crime while walking in his neighborhood early on Jan. 29, 2019. He also testified that a $3,500 check he wrote for Abimbola Osundairo



was for meal and workout plans because he was trying to get toned for an upcoming music video.

Under cross-examination by special prosecutor Dan Webb, Smollett said Tuesday that a few days before the alleged attack he collected Osundairo in his car to go work out and that Osundairo's brother, Olabingo, came along. Smollett denied the brothers' testimony that they circled the area where the alleged attack occurred three times as a "dry run" for the fake assault. He said it wasn't unusual for him to drive around in circles, and that he canceled the plan to work out because he didn't want to work out with Olabingo Osundairo, whom he hadn't invited along.

Horoscope

Tarot.com

Aries: *It's a good day to move out of the fast lane and let yourself coast along at a gentler speed. The Moon enters your sleepy 12th House of Solitude and Subconscious this morning, gifting you with an opportunity to rest up and enjoy some quiet time to rejuvenate.*

Taurus: *Your connections with others become a higher priority today as the sentimental Moon moves into your 11th House of Friendship. This is a reminder that sometimes you need to put work on the backburner to make time for the people you care about.*

Gemini: *Your working life gets a jolt today as the intuitive Moon zips into your career sector, helping you make the right moves that can lead to success. Hit the ground running and be ready to show people what you can do at a moment's notice!*

Cancer: *You have a lot of support to expand your world today, whether it's literally or figuratively. The Moon is moving into your boundless 9th House of Culture and Higher Learning, turning on the invisible light bulb over your head.*

Leo: *Be prepared to turn inward and take a good, hard look at yourself, Leo. The Moon slips into your intense 8th House of Transformation and Deep Bonding today, so you're probably not in a lighthearted or easygoing mood.*

Virgo: *The way you handle your partnerships is up for review today as the Moon enters your relationship sector. When it comes to your most important one-on-one connections, it's time to think less along the lines of "me" and more along "we."*

Libra: *Your attention is being drawn toward your own health and well-being today, and you have the universe's support to take some positive steps toward feeling better. Look around your life at the details -- nutrition, workload.*

Scorpio: *You might feel like some barriers around you are being lifted today, giving you more opportunity to enjoy the world around you. The Moon is dancing into your 5th House of Pleasure today, so do something that brings a smile to your face.*

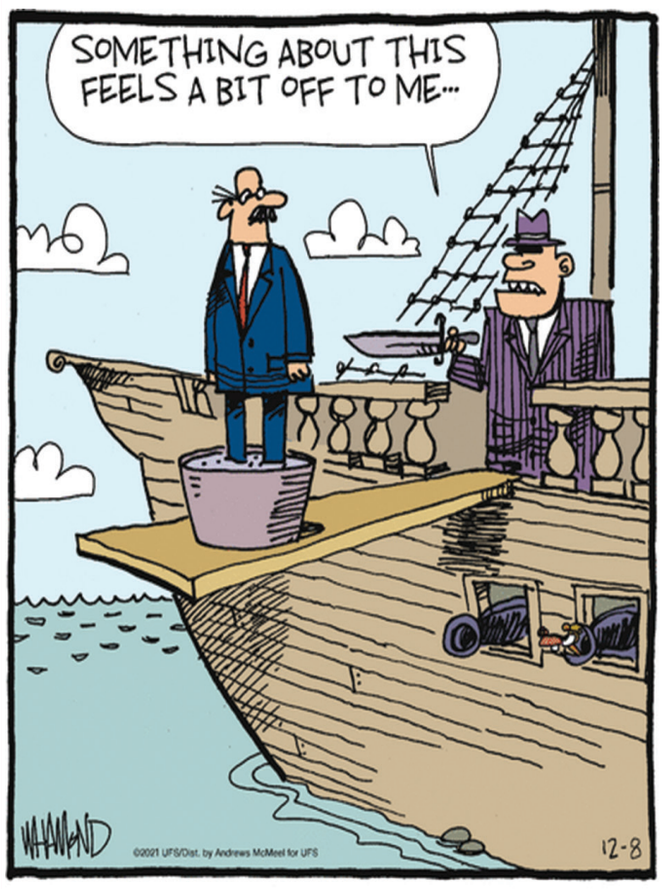
Sagittarius: *Reconnecting with your roots could create a lot of fulfillment, purpose, and understanding for you today. Think about what, who, and where you come from and examine how your early stages turned you into the person you are now.*

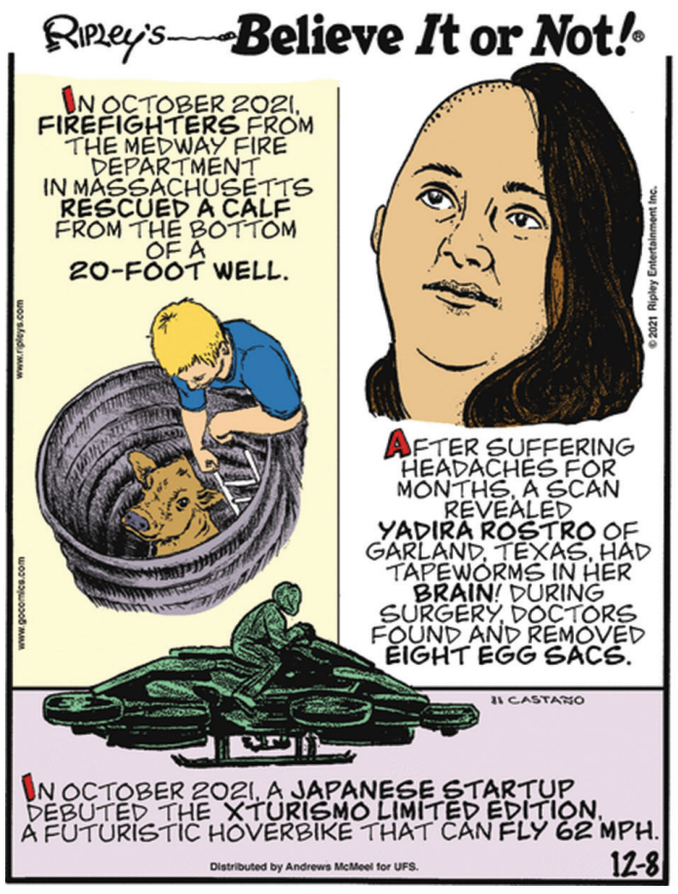
Capricorn: *Life picks up the pace today as the Moon steps into your busy 3rd House of Communication and Information this morning, making it imperative that you keep your eye on the ball. Fortunately, your sign tends to stay on top of things .*

Aquarius: *It's a good day to get back to basics, especially when it comes to matters of money and material security. The Moon moves into your 2nd House of Income and Possessions today, so go through your recent spending.*

Pisces: *You're very good at making time for other people, but have you been making enough time for yourself? If your desires or needs have been getting pushed to the side, then you need to recalibrate.*

Cartoon





SPORTS

Holders Machhindra back on track beating Jawalakhel 2-0

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec 8

Defending champions Machhindra Football Club moved to the second spot of the ongoing Martyr's Memorial 'A' Division League after beating Jawalakhel Youth Club at Dashrath Stadium, Tripureshwor, Kathmandu on Wednesday.

After 2-0 victory over Jawalakhel, Machhindra moved to the second spot with seven points from three matches they played while with an equal seven points from three matches newcomer Satdobato Youth Club is at the summit of the league standing in the goal difference. With an equal seven points from three matches eight time champion Manang Marsyangdi Club is at the third spot in the goal difference.

Similarly, the departmental side Armed Police Force (APF), is at bottom of the league standing with zero points from three matches they played. Ranjit Dhimal scored a one goal while Simant Thapa of Jawalakhel gifted one goal for holders Machhindra Football Club.

The own goal from Jawalakhel's Simant put Machhindra ahead in the 14th minute. Simant suicide goal came while clearing the cross off Machhindra's striker Manish Dangi.

Jawalakhel failed to level the score in the 19th minute after their forward Onguna Nkengue Junior's goal was ruled off side by referee Suman Shrestha.

Machhindra double their tally in the 22nd minute after their defender Ranjit Dhimal scored from free kick. This is the third defeat in a row for Jawalakhel.



Ravi Shankar Paswan of Nepal Police Club (blue) and defender Amrit Shrestha of Himalayan Sherpa Club vie for the ball during the Martyr's Memorial 'A' Division League held at Dashrath Stadium, Kathmandu on Wednesday. (Photo: Bikash/TRN)

Earlier, Machhindra thrashed New Road Team by 2-1 in their opener and then played a goalless draw againstTribhuvan Army Football Club in the second match of the league. Earlier Jawalakhel went down to Manang Marsyangdi Club by 1-0 in the first match and they suffered a 1-0 defeat at the hands of Nepal Police Club in the second match of the league.

Machhindra Coach Prabesh Katuwal was pleased to earn three points from Jawalakhel who was one of the sound and strongest sides of the ongoing league.

"Scoring an early goal against Jawalakhel put us in a comfort zone as the victory has put us on the top of the league standing. Andres Nia Tchounkeu who absent today's game and we fielded our second choice Abhiyan Pradhan, who played well," Coach Katuwal said.

After suffering consecutive defeats , Jawalakhel coach Kishor K.C. blamed his goalie Tikendra Singh Thapa for his poor keeping in all three matches of the league.

"We had three goalies in our squad and two goalies is inexperienced. I will take a risk in the upcoming matches of the league by giving chance to the second choice goalie ," Coach K.C said.

Police, Sherpa share point

Nepal Police Club and Himalayan Sherpa Club shared a point each in th league after they played 1-1 draw at Dashrath Stadium.

After the draw, the departmental side Police moved to the fifth position with five points from three matches and Sherpa remained at the 12th spot of the league standing as they have gained only two points from three matches they played.

Biswash Shrestha scored for Sherpa and Suman Lama rescued Police men from the jaw of defeat by scoring an equalizer.

Sherpa's captain Biswash Shrestha put Sherpa ahead within 53 seconds of the kick-off whistle. Lama scored a stunner from outside the box off the pass of India forward Moinuddin Khan.

Sherpa failed to take advantage of the early lead. After the interval the policemen played an attacking game and levelled the score 1-1 in the 60th minute through Suman Lama goal. Nnmarked Lama rescued Police from inside the six yard box connecting the cross off Ravi Shankar Paswan.

Jiwan Gurung of Himalayan Sherpa Club was declared the Man of the Match. Himalayan Sherpa Caoch Yugal Kishore Rai said that they failed to perform according to their plan against the policemen and were forced to share point.

"Winning or losing is a natural thing in a game but our calculation did not work properly for us today. We have to share a point against policemen after we failed on execute our strategy. I trained my boys how to stop policemen but they completely failed to executed this plan," Coach Rai said. After sharing a point, Police Coach Anant Thapa said that they were here to earn three points but they failed on it

"I had already said all both teams are 19-20 position in the league and earning three points is a tough task and conceding unbelievable goal in the first minute put us under a huge pressure against Sherpa. I am happy after out team emerged unbeaten at the end of third round," Coach Thapa said.

Atletico qualify as Liverpool complete perfect Champions League group stage



Porto's Evanilson vies for the ball with Atletico Madrid's Thomas Lemar, right, during the Champions League Group B soccer match between FC Porto and Atletico Madrid at the Dragao stadium in Porto, Portugal, Tuesday. (Photo: AP)

AFP
Porto, Dec. 8

Atletico Madrid won a bad-tempered game in Porto on Tuesday to qualify for the last 16 of the Champions League as Liverpool and Ajax both completed the group stage with 100 percent records.

Diego Simeone's Atletico, who lost to Real Madrid in the 2014 and 2016 finals, needed to beat Porto in Portugal to advance to the knockout phase and they duly triumphed 3-1 in a game which featured three red cards.

Antoine Griezmann put the Spanish champions ahead in the 56th minute at the Estadio do Dragao but they then had Yannick Carrasco sent off for wrestling Otavio to the ground.

With tempers flaring, Porto were also reduced to 10 men as Wendell was sent off for elbowing Atletico's Matheus Cunha in the neck, before their substitute goalkeeper Agustin Marchesin also saw red.

With Porto pushing forward in search of the draw they needed to qualify, Atletico got their second goal on the break in the last minute through Angel Correa before Rodrigo De Paul scored their third in injury time. Sergio Oliveira's penalty was a mere consolation for Porto.

Atletico finish second in Group B, a huge 11 points behind group winners Liverpool, who made it six wins out of six in Europe this season by beating AC Milan 2-1 at San Siro despite fielding a virtual reserve side.

Rabi moves to top on Day-III



By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

Rabi Khadka moved to the top on the third day of the Surya Nepal Kathmandu Open at the Royal Nepal Golf Club on Wednesday.

Rabi carded two-under 66 to post the 54-hole total score of seven-under 197 in the season-opening event under the Surya Nepal Golf Tour 2021-22. He is two strokes ahead of three pros, Dinesh Prajapati, Jayaram Shrestha and Nepal No 1 Bhuwan Nagarkoti. Dinesh carded three-under 65, while Jayaram shot one-under 67 and overnight leader Bhuwan played one-over 69 on the third day.

Bhuwan Kumar Rokka moved to fifth at three-under 201 after he carded five-under 63, while amateur Subash Tamang shot two-over 70 to slip down to sixth at two-under 202. Dhana Bahadur Thapa carded second straight 68 to remain at sixth among pros and seventh overall at even-par 204.

Sukra Bahadur Rai (68), Kumar Kami (71) and Sanjay Lama (71) shared the eighth position at 205, while Ramesh Adhikari (69) was further four shots behind at 11th position. Niraj Tamang and Krishna Man Rajbahak shared the 12th position at 212, while Basanta Raj Gurung, Rajendra Shrestha Pradhan and Surya Prasad Sharma were tied on 213.

Leader Rabi played even-par 34 on the front nine before carding two-under 32 on the back nine. He began the day with a birdie and dropped a shot on the ninth before taking the turn. Rabi carded birdies on the 10th and 13th holes on the back nine.

Dinesh took the turn at three-under 31 and played even-par 34 on the back nine. He carded a birdie on the third and sank an eagle on the fourth, while he earned shots on the 10th and 12th holes before facing bogeys on the 15th and 18th holes.

Starc's first-ball wicket is fodder for a new Ashes memory

AP
Brisbane, Dec. 8

When it comes to first-ball folklore in the Ashes, new Australia captain Pat Cummins thinks it's time for a hit to take precedence over a miss.

Left-arm pace bowler Mitchell Starc took out Rory Burns' leg stump with a swinging yorker on the first delivery of the Ashes series on Wednesday, and England lost its first wicket before scoring a run in the opening test at the Gabba.

It set in motion two sessions of dominance from Australia's bowling attack, which dismissed England for 147 before heavy rain and bad light combined to bring an early end to play on Day 1. The dismissal of Burns was instantly compared with a fateful first-ball moment for Steve Harmison, the England paceman who bowled so wide on the opening delivery of the 2006 series at the Gabba that it was fielded at second slip.

England had entered that series on the back of a drought-breaking Ashes triumph at home in 2005, but surrendered the old urn in a thumping 5-0 series defeat in 2006-07.

On Wednesday, Cummins returned a five-wicket haul in his first innings as Australia's test captain, and his pace bowling partners Starc and Josh Hazlewood took two wickets each.



Australia's Mitchell Starc, left, celebrates after taking the wicket of England's Rory Burns during day one of the first Ashes cricket test between Australia and England at The Gabba in Brisbane, Australia, Wednesday. (Photo: AP)

Rather than focus on Burns' batting, Cummins praised Starc's impact on the game.

"When you think of the first ball of an Ashes series, everyone goes back to Harmison," Cummins said. "So hopefully that's the new memory now. Just great, so happy for," Starc.

"He's got a knack of picking up a wicket in the first couple of overs. Pumped for him more than anything else. Just excited, great way to start it off."

Starc, who took a key wicket in the first over of the 2015 Cricket World Cup final to set up Australia's win over New Zealand, simply said it was nice to "get it in the right spot to start the day" against England.

Sajid's bowling leads Pakistan past Bangladesh in 2nd test

AP
Dhaka, Dec. 8

Offspinner Sajid Khan ended with a match haul of 12-128 as Pakistan broke Bangladesh's stubborn resistance to secure an innings and eight-run victory in the rain-hit second and final test on Wednesday.

Bangladesh was forced to follow-on after being wrapped up for 87 in the first innings and was bowled out for 205.

With the light gradually fading, Bangladesh's last-wicket pair of Taijul Islam and Ebadot Hossain resisted for 34 balls to raise a hope of salvaging the test.

But Sajid broke the partnership, dismissing Taijul leg-before to help Pakistan win the game. Sajid claimed 4-86 to follow up his opening 8-42, the fourth-best total by a Pakastani bowler in an innings.

"The team, the captain trusted me to do the job," Sajid said. "The plan was to go for the win, and we tried to keep it tight and bowl on one spot. The entire team gets credit for their effort."

Pakistan declared its first innings at 300-4 after only 63.2 overs were possible in the first three days because of rain and bad light. The third day was entirely washed out and only 6.2 overs were possible on Day 2.

Resuming on 76-7, Bangladesh was quickly dismissed for 87 and Babar Azam forced the follow-on.

Weather

Thursday
Sunrise at 6:43 am
Sunset at 5:09 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Generally cloudy in Bagmati Province, Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Paschim Province , partly cloudy in rest of the Provinces. Light to moderate rain is possible at some places of Bagmati Province, Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province. Chances of light to moderate snowfall at some places of the central and western high mountaineous regions.

Expected Temp.:20- 22 °C
Rain Probability: 60%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	26.2	12.4	0.0
Dadeldhura	17.6	7.7	0.0
Dhangadi	27.2	14.5	0.0
Birendranagar	25.5	10.8	0.0
Nepalgunj	28.2	14.0	0.0
Jumla	17.4	-0.5	0.0
Ghorahi	25.5	12.0	0.0
Pokhara	24.5	13.1	Traces
Bhairahawa	32.4	14.6	0.0
Simara	29.5	16.8	0.0
Kathmandu	23.1	10.4	0.0
Okhaldhunga	21.3	5.9	0.0
Taplejung	19.6	8.8	0.0
Dhankuta	24.0	11.5	0.0
Biratnagar	29.2	14.5	0.0
Jomsom	18.0	3.2	0.0*
Dharan	28.5	16.5	0.0*
Lumle	19.0	9.0	0.0*
Jankapur	30.0	15.8	0.0*
Jiri	18.4	5.5	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 9, 2021

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates

For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 120.43	Rs. 121.03
Euro	1	Rs. 135.87	Rs. 136.55
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 159.44	Rs. 160.24
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 130.29	Rs. 130.94
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 85.90	Rs. 86.33
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 95.38	Rs. 95.85
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 88.24	Rs. 88.68
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 10.61	Rs. 10.66
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.97	Rs. 19.06
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 32.10	Rs. 32.26
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 33.08	Rs. 33.24
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.60	Rs. 3.62
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 32.79	Rs. 32.95
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.51	Rs. 28.65
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.23	Rs. 10.28
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.26	Rs. 13.32
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 18.27	Rs. 18.36
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 15.44	Rs. 15.52
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 397.68	Rs. 399.66
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 319.42	Rs. 321.01

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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THE RISING NEPAL

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ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Biratnagar Edition



Limbu music videos to preserve Limbu culture: P.7



Govt, ADBL ink agreement for VITA Project: P.2

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President opens reconstruction meet

Nepal's post-quake reconstruction unprecedented

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

The international community has termed Nepal's post-quake reconstruction campaign successful and 'unprecedented event' in post-disaster management.

Speaking at the International Conference on Nepal's Reconstruction (ICNR) 2021 organised by National Reconstruction Authority (NRA) and inaugurated by President Bidya Devi Bhandari on Wednesday in the Capital, they expressed satisfaction over the timely completion of the reconstruction of private houses, heritages and infrastructures damaged in the 2015 earthquake.

Meanwhile, through the conference, Nepal has sent appreciation to the supporters, donors and collaborators of the reconstruction.

Foreign Minister of China, Wang Yi, congratulated Nepal government and people, and said that the northern neighbour would continue support to Nepal in rehabilitating livelihood. He also pledged to enhance vaccine cooperation. However, he maintained that there would not be any political conditions for any Chinese cooperation to Nepal.



President Bidya Devi Bhandari addressing the International Conference on Nepal's Reconstruction 2021 held in the capital on Wednesday.
(Photo: Sujan Gurung/TRN)

Expressing happiness over the near-completion of the reconstruction in a video message, Minister Wang said that China supported Nepal in the reconstruction of the projects like Nine-Storey Palace, Arniko Highway and Durbar High School.

Indian Minister for External Affairs, S. Jaishankar, also remembered in his video message that India started supporting Nepal government six hours after the quake struck the country.

"India will always come forward to support Nepal and its people in need. India has supported the reconstruction of about 50,000 quake-damaged houses in Nuwakot and Gorkha districts," he said.

Remarkable success

Speaking at the conference, Ambassador of the United States of America to Nepal, Randy Berry, said that his country has been helping Nepal in combating disasters and climate change. "The USA has provided support of US$240 million to Nepal after the 2015 quake," he said. According to him, Nepal has achieved a remarkable success in the post-quake reconstruction.

Neil Buhne, Regional Director for the UN Development Coordination Office, said that Nepal is extremely vulnerable to the effects of climate change as well as floods and landslides and expressed concerns that vulnerable people experience the major setbacks during the hard times.

Japanese Parliamentary Vice Minister for Foreign Affairs, Honda Taro, congratulated Nepal over the success of the reconstruction campaign. "This is not a small feat. Japan knows what it takes to recover and the hardships that accompany the process of reconstruction," he said.

According to him, Japan had pledged the support of US$260 million at the first edition of ICNR in June 2015. Japan has long been supporting Nepal in the field of disaster reduction and risk mitigation.

See page 6

PM for convening 19th SAARC Summit early

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8



Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba stressed the need to drive the SAARC process with a forward-looking perspective and revitalize it including through an early convening of the 19th Summit.

Extending greetings to the peoples and governments of the member states on the occasion of the 37th SAARC Charter Day, the Prime Minister said an embodiment of common aspirations for peace, stability and prosperity, the Charter was a blueprint of regional cooperation and partnership.

Over the period of three decades and a half, the regional efforts aimed at promoting the welfare of our peoples have yielded some notable progress, said Prime Minister Deuba adding, “However, the Charter objectives and aspirations are far from being fully realized.”

“Our endeavours to promote regional harmony, end poverty and inequality, and build just and inclusive societies are yet to gather requisite strength,” he added.

The Prime Minister referred to the challenges and vulnerabilities posed by the COVID-19 pandemic and underlined the need to re-embrace regional understanding and solidarity, with a focus on resilient recovery and building back better.

“We must strive towards deeper regional integration with a focus on resilient recovery and building back better,” the Prime Minister said.

He also reiterated Nepal’s commitment to playing a constructive role in enabling the organisation to deliver wider benefits for the peoples of the region and urged the Member States to promote more effective and result-oriented SAARC grounded in cooperation, trust and understanding.

Our endeavours to promote regional harmony, end poverty and inequality, and build just and inclusive societies are yet to gather requisite strength.

Home to over one-fifth of humanity, South Asia is a region of immense potentials common values and socio-cultural affinities, the Prime Minister said, adding, “In order to unlock these potentials, we must muster political will and drive the regional process with a forward-looking perspective.”

Vivah Panchami observed in Janakpur

By Dharbendra Jha
Janakpurdham, Dec. 8

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Ram Tapeshwor Das, priest of Janaki Temple, said, "After the conclusion of the Swayambhar ceremony, the wedding ceremony of Lord Ram and Goddess Sita will be held on the temple premises on Wednesday night as per the Mithila rituals."

NC leaders in hectic parleys to decide on consensus candidates

By Ram Prasad Dahal
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

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Moreover, the Paudel faction could not pick a single candidate for party president despite its marathon meetings on Tuesday and Wednesday.

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The NC Central Election Committee has already made public the calendar of election programme under 14th general convention. As per the calendar, voters’ list would be made public on December 10, the day when the general convention will begin. Likewise, the candidates should file their nominations on December 11 and voting will take place on December 13.



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After the meeting, leader Dila Sagraula informed that the meeting unanimously asked Deuba to stand for party president for the next term.

The meeting decided that the panel of Deuba loyal candidates would contest election under the leadership of Prime Minister Deuba.

In the meeting, Home Minister Bal Krishna Khand, Minister for Communication and Information Technology Gyanendra Bahadur Karki, joint general secretary Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, spokesperson Bishwa Prakash Sharma and leader NP Saud claimed for party general secretary from the team.

Other leaders also claimed for the post of party office bearers. However, the meeting did not take any decision.

The meeting gave the responsibility to nine central leaders to prepare the list of Central Working Committee member aspirants from the panel.

Saud and Ramesh Lekhak, general secretary Purna Bahadur Khadka and Karnali Province Chief Minister and NC leader Jeevan Bahadur Shahi, Home Minister Khand, leader Gopal Man Shrestha, Dr. Mahat, Ramesh Rijal and Minister and leader Karki got the responsibility to prepare the list from Sudurpaschim, Karnali, Lumbini, Gandaki, Bagmati, Province 2 and Province 1 respectively. The meeting is to continue on Thursday.

The faction led by Paudel held its meeting at the Chaksibari-based residence of leader Prakash Man Singh. But the meeting failed to garner consensus after Singh stood firm about his candidacy for party president. Senior leader Paudel, general secretary Dr. Shashank Koirala and leader Dr. Shekhar Koirala, however, were in favour of consensus.

After the meeting, leader Guru Ghimire informed that the meeting failed to pick a single candidate for party president from the rival faction as Singh did not budge from his claim.

Leader Hirdayaram Thani also said the Central Working Committee members loyal to Paudel faction asked the four leader to reach a consensus. “They have to learn from their fathers, who did not show greed for any political post,” he said.

See page 6

'Make Nepali products more competitive'



By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

Finance Minister Janardan Sharma has said that domestic products must be made competitive to replace imports.

Addressing the 45th annual general meeting of NADA Automobiles Association of Nepal on Wednesday, Minister Sharma said that domestic products should be made competitive instead of restricting imports.

"We need a policy to make domestic goods competitive. I am not saying that imports should be banned. This is not possible today because of various international laws and treaties," he said.

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India’s defence chief killed in helicopter crash

AP
New Delhi, Dec. 8

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The dead included Rawat’s wife. The air force said one officer, Group Capt. Varun Singh, survived and is being treated in a military hospital.

Public broadcaster Prasar Bharati said the Mi-17V5 helicopter was on its way from an air force base to the army defense services college when it crashed near the town of Coonoor, a hill station in Tamil Nadu. The reason for the crash was not immediately known.

Television images from the crash site showed plumes of smoke billowing from the debris as local residents tried to put out the fire and remove bodies from the wreckage.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said Rawat contributed greatly to modernizing the country’s armed forces. “His insights and perspectives on strategic matters were exceptional,” Modi said.

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Valley hospitals prepare to fight probable Omicron cases

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The new variant of COVID-19, known as Omicron, has already spread in scores of countries across the world. So far, Nepal has recorded two cases of Omicron variant some 12 days after it was reported for the first time by South Africa and four days after it was detected in India.

The Ministry of Health and Population (MoHP) had confirmed two cases of Omicron variant on Monday, December 6. The World Health Organisation (WHO) has already classified Omicron as the 'Variant of Concern'.

The MoHP has requested the public to continue following all the health and safety standards and participating in the government's vaccination drive to stay safe from the variant. Dr. Santosh Dulal, research scientist and COVID-19 lab chief at Aanandaban Hospital, said that abiding by the public health standards was vital as the Omicron variant could possibly spread faster than other variants.

Similarly, Dr. Sher Bahadur Pun, chief of clinical research unit at Teku Hospital, said that rather than being terrified of the new variant, we should focus on alertness. "As researches are underway to determine the severity and transmissibility of Omicron, we are currently at 'wait and see ' situation," he said.

Dr. Manisha Rawal, director of Teku Hospital, also said that following public health standards could prevent the rapid spread of the new variant.

While the cases of new variant are being seen in the USA, India, UK and other European countries, the government is mulling over the measures to prevent the spread. The COVID-19 hospitals within the Kathmandu Valley have already adopted high alertness.



Armed Police Force Hospital

Dr. Prabin Nepal, focal person of the hospital, informed that the hospital was ready to battle the new variant in case it spread rapidly. "We have readied isolation ward with 200 beds. Also, if the cases of new variant start increasing, then we will separate 30 beds for Intensive Care Unit (ICU)," he added.

Dr. Nepal said that an oxygen plant of 100 litres had been installed in the hospital and the hospital was planning to set up another oxygen plant with a capacity of 200 litres.

Civil Service Hospital

Civil Service Hospital is also prepared to fight the new variant, informed Dr. Bidesh Bista, focal person of the hospital. He said, "Our hospital had started preparations for the possible third wave. Thus, we are already prepared to tackle Omicron variant."

Dr. Bista informed that 50 High Dependency Units and 15 ICU beds were separated for COVID-19 patients. We are preparing to begin the operation of COVID-19 ward within a week, he said, adding that an oxygen plant with 200 litres capacity had been installed in the hospital.

See page 6

THE RISING NEPAL

NATION'S FIRST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

Kohalpur Edition



Limbu music videos to preserve Limbu culture: P.7



Govt, ADBL ink agreement for VITA Project: P.2

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President opens reconstruction meet

Nepal's post-quake reconstruction unprecedented

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8

The international community has termed Nepal's post-quake reconstruction campaign successful and 'unprecedented event' in post-disaster management.

Speaking at the International Conference on Nepal's Reconstruction (ICNR) 2021 organised by National Reconstruction Authority (NRA) and inaugurated by President Bidya Devi Bhandari on Wednesday in the Capital, they expressed satisfaction over the timely completion of the reconstruction of private houses, heritages and infrastructures damaged in the 2015 earthquake.

Meanwhile, through the conference, Nepal has sent appreciation to the supporters, donors and collaborators of the reconstruction.

Foreign Minister of China, Wang Yi, congratulated Nepal government and people, and said that the northern neighbour would continue support to Nepal in rehabilitating livelihood. He also pledged to enhance vaccine cooperation. However, he maintained that there would not be any political conditions for any Chinese cooperation to Nepal.



President Bidya Devi Bhandari addressing the International Conference on Nepal's Reconstruction 2021 held in the capital on Wednesday.
(Photo: Sujan Gurung/TRN)

Expressing happiness over the near-completion of the reconstruction in a video message, Minister Wang said that China supported Nepal in the reconstruction of the projects like Nine-Storey Palace, Arniko Highway and Durbar High School.

Indian Minister for External Affairs, S. Jaishankar, also remembered in his video message that India started supporting Nepal government six hours after the quake struck the country.

"India will always come forward to support Nepal and its people in need. India has supported the reconstruction of about 50,000 quake-damaged houses in Nuwakot and Gorkha districts," he said.

Remarkable success

Speaking at the conference, Ambassador of the United States of America to Nepal, Randy Berry, said that his country has been helping Nepal in combating disasters and climate change. "The USA has provided support of US$240 million to Nepal after the 2015 quake," he said. According to him, Nepal has achieved a remarkable success in the post-quake reconstruction.

Neil Buhne, Regional Director for the UN Development Coordination Office, said that Nepal is extremely vulnerable to the effects of climate change as well as floods and landslides and expressed concerns that vulnerable people experience the major setbacks during the hard times.

Japanese Parliamentary Vice Minister for Foreign Affairs, Honda Taro, congratulated Nepal over the success of the reconstruction campaign. "This is not a small feat. Japan knows what it takes to recover and the hardships that accompany the process of reconstruction," he said.

According to him, Japan had pledged the support of US$260 million at the first edition of ICNR in June 2015. Japan has long been supporting Nepal in the field of disaster reduction and risk mitigation.

See page 6

PM for convening 19th SAARC Summit early

By A Staff Reporter
Kathmandu, Dec. 8



Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba stressed the need to drive the SAARC process with a forward-looking perspective and revitalize it including through an early convening of the 19th Summit.

Extending greetings to the peoples and governments of the member states on the occasion of the 37th SAARC Charter Day, the Prime Minister said an embodiment of common aspirations for peace, stability and prosperity, the Charter was a blueprint of regional cooperation and partnership.

Over the period of three decades and a half, the regional efforts aimed at promoting the welfare of our peoples have yielded some notable progress, said Prime Minister Deuba adding, "However, the Charter objectives and aspirations are far from being fully realized."

"Our endeavours to promote regional harmony, end poverty and inequality, and build just and inclusive societies are yet to gather requisite strength," he added.

The Prime Minister referred to the challenges and vulnerabilities posed by the COVID-19 pandemic and underlined the need to re-embrace regional understanding and solidarity, with a focus on resilient recovery and building back better.

"We must strive towards deeper regional integration with a focus on resilient recovery and building back better," the Prime Minister said.

He also reiterated Nepal's commitment to playing a constructive role in enabling the organisation to deliver wider benefits for the peoples of the region and urged the Member States to promote more effective and result-oriented SAARC grounded in cooperation, trust and understanding.

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